

Leading an Organisation During the COVID-19 Crisis

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Declaration of Originality

In presenting this dissertation for assessment, I, Volha Mitra, declare that it is entirely the result of my own work other than where sources are explicitly acknowledged and referenced within the body of the text. This dissertation has not been previously submitted, in whole or in substantial part, for any degree at this or any other institution. It is being submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of Master of Business Administration: Innovation Leadership and Consulting at York St. John University, United Kingdom.

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Abstract

A year and a half ago we were faced with an unprecedented challenge on a global scale, the COVID-19 pandemic. This contagious monster terrorised the world population and took the subject of crisis to whole another level. Therefore, it is important to gain a better understanding of the topic in the current context by inquiring into this ongoing phenomenon. Although the study does not represent the population at large, it informs of management missteps during the crisis and might benefit the organisation at the centre of this research.

The purpose of the paper is to identify what leadership processes and behaviours can sustain performance during the COVID-19 crisis within a case study organisation, and what is perceived as important. It is an exploratory qualitative study that used a semi-structured interview method by enquiring into the challenges employees faced during the crisis, how the organisation reacted to the crisis, and thoughts on leadership during the crisis. Data gathered from twelve participants was analysed using a reflexive approach to Thematic Analysis. Developed themes uncovered an array of ideas, leadership processes and behaviours which have been clustered into three main topics – organisational preparedness and survival, importance of effective crisis communication, and the impact of collaborative behaviour on organisational ability to innovate. The findings from the collected data were analysed using an abductive approach by moving between the data and relevant academic literature, based on which conclusions and recommendations were drawn.

This study demonstrates the importance and need for collaborative, participative leadership behaviour during the crisis. However, it also poses a leadership dilemma where collaboration may not always be possible, as organisational survival may be contingent upon a leader's ability to react quickly to avoid an imminent threat. The study reveals the significance of empathy and leadership's ability to address employees' psychological needs during the COVID-19 crisis, through active communication to promote a sense of stability and trust. It discusses and provides some evidence to suggest that, in a situation of a dispersed workforce, organisational readiness and ability to address and establish remote work practices and procedures might have a significant impact on crisis management. The findings from this study can be further developed by testing established themes through quantitative analysis on a larger population, through surveys and questionnaires.

Table of Contents

List of Abbreviations	7
1. Introduction.....	8
1.1 Background	8
1.2 Case Study Organisation (Company A).....	9
1.3 Research Question and Objectives	10
1.4 Synopsis.....	10
2. Literature Review	12
2.1 Crisis Leadership.....	12
2.1.1 Defining Crisis.....	12
2.1.2 Defining Leadership	14
2.1.3 Crisis Leadership Behaviours.....	15
2.2 Crisis Leadership Under COVID-19 Pandemic and Remote Work Practices	16
2.2.1 Act with Urgency	18
2.2.2 Communicate with Transparency	19
2.2.3 Reassess and Adapt Continuously.....	20
2.2.4 Accept Responsibility and Promote Innovation	20
2.3 Conclusion	22
3. Research Methodology	23
3.1 Research Philosophy and Design.....	23
3.2 Data Collection Method	24
3.3 Primary Data Analysis.....	26
3.4 Research Ethics	27
3.5 Validity and Bias	28
4. Research Findings and Discussion	29
4.1 Presentation of Findings	29
4.1.1 Theme 1: Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response	30
4.1.2 Theme 2: Survival of the business as a top priority	31
4.1.3 Theme 3: Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively	31
4.1.4 Theme 4: The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment	32
4.1.5 Theme 5: Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.....	33
4.1.6 Theme 6: Job security is of the highest priority for the employees during the crisis	34
4.1.7 Theme 7: Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities	35
4.1.8 Theme 8: Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business	36
4.1.9 Theme 9: Innovating is the way to sustain the business.....	37

4.1.10	Theme 10: The new normal presents tighter financial control	38
4.1.11	Theme 11: Remote teamwork does not have the same ease of communication	38
4.1.12	Theme 12: Effective personal safety measures reduce worry during the pandemic	39
4.2	Discussion	40
4.2.1	Organisational Preparedness and Survival.....	41
4.2.2	The Importance of Effective Crisis Communication	42
4.2.3	Promote Collaboration to Foster Innovative Behaviour	43
4.3	Conclusion	44
5.	Conclusions and Recommendations.....	45
5.1	Conclusion and Recommendations.....	45
5.2	Study Limitations and Future Research	47
6.	Reflection on Dissertation Process	49
	References	53
	Appendices	58
	Appendix A: HARP Self-Assessment (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015, pp. 153-156).....	58
	Appendix B: Interview Questions	62
	Appendix C: Participant Information Sheet – Email example (based on Fisher and Buglear, 2010, pp. 76-77).....	63
	Appendix D: Research Consent Form - Signed Example.....	64
	Appendix E: Partial Interview Transcripts, Codes and Themes	65
	Appendix F: Research Ethics Form (RKC Online Campus -Thesis Repository)	73

List of Abbreviations

AI	Appreciative Inquiry
BI	Behavioural Interviewing
CEO	Chief Executive Officer
COVID-19	Coronavirus Disease 2019
GCC	Gulf Cooperation Council
HARP	Heightening your Awareness of your Research Philosophy
HQ	Head Quarters
HR	Human Resources
KSA	Kingdom of Saudi Arabia
LX	Leader X
MLT	Motivating Language Theory
P	Interview Participant
PHS	Interview Participant with Half Salary
PWS	Interview Participant Without Salary
SME	Small and Medium-Sized Enterprise
TA	Thematic Analysis
UAE	United Arab Emirates
VT	Virtual Team
WHO	World Health Organization

1. Introduction

1.1 Background

On March 11, 2020, the World Health Organisation categorised the outbreak of COVID-19, caused by a novel coronavirus, as a pandemic and recommended the social isolation of humans as the most efficient way to stop the spread, which resulted in a devastating impact on various sectors of modern society (Yan, 2020). This unprecedented event brought the topic of crisis leadership and crisis management to the top of every organisational agenda, as the whole world is tackling a pandemic not confined by borders (McNulty and Marcus, 2020). While the subject of crisis leadership is not in any way new, the situation we found ourselves in certainly is; therefore, we can describe the COVID-19 crisis as novel with respect to crisis leadership.

Personal safety, the safety of employees, remote work, financial survival of firms are only a few of many subjects organisations and their leaders were faced with, and while some organisations will come out from the other end as resilient, for many, the aftermath is or could be catastrophic.

A year into the pandemic, the newness and scale of disruptive forces, which come in waves but have the effect of a tsunami, are far from over. Even as hope appears tangible with the arrival of the COVID-19 vaccines, for many leaders, the "decision making is [...] hazardous", and the outcomes are unpredictable (Tourish, 2020, p. 261).

Thus, many questions arise. What good leaders should do, and how they should act during this novel crisis? Should leaders foster collaboration and transparency by promoting a sense of "us-ness" (Haslam, Reicher and Platow, 2020) by exercising inclusive leadership or take a directive and coercive approach (Stoker, Garretsen, and Soudis, 2019)? Which of the pre-pandemic leaders' strategic crisis responses and behaviours are relevant in today's conditions? Leading and managing organisations in the current uncertainty is a new issue, not just from the health perspective of individuals within an organisation, but also in the context of organisational survival, and is yet to be investigated to its full extent.

It is important to gain an understanding of what it means to lead during this novel crisis from the theoretical standpoint as well as a practical perspective, in a specific context, as situational variables are numerous for different organisations, countries, or industries.

For example, the common practice, with devastating effects, was a shutdown of non-essential businesses across the globe, and while some countries developed policies to support increased unemployment and provided funding to the private and public sector, others did not have social support structures, and private business owners and employees were left in a dire situation.

1.2 Case Study Organisation (Company A)

While many countries were, and are, facing multiple lockdown measures, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) has been relatively successful in the containment of the virus by implementing strict lockdowns at the early stages of the pandemic, by administering mask-wearing mandates and social distancing rules, and where any noncompliance or violation would entail substantial monetary penalties. The government response, combined with the rapid vaccination programs, resulted in a partial reopening of the businesses as early as June 2020 (Haque, 2021) and further lifting of travel restrictions and authorizations of most businesses to resume in September 2020. Such actions took UAE to the recovery phase earlier than many other developed countries (Augustine, 2021).

Company A is a medium-sized enterprise (SME), a regional distributor of the premium personal care and fragrance brands in the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), with the Head Quarters based in the UAE. It consists of a team of forty-two employees, with a well-established operation in the UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, and Oman.

As a Head of Business Development, the researcher's role is to assist company leadership, and its respective departments, with the development of the brand portfolio and growth of the regional distribution network, by establishing and maintaining effective operational links between departments, support functions, and external stakeholders, such as company clients and suppliers.

At the early stages of the pandemic, during the lockdowns, all non-essential businesses were shut, and Company A was no exception. With the closure of the retail businesses, Company A's revenue dropped to almost non-existent, and most of the employees were forced to take three months unpaid leaves and, upon the slow reopening of the operation in July, returned at half pay for the duration of six months. Even though the

Company A employees faced drastic but temporary pay cuts, no personnel faced redundancies or layoffs, and operation returned to a relatively stable state by January 2021.

The study aims to investigate what leadership processes and behaviours were, and are, exercised by company leadership during the COVID-19 crisis and what is perceived as important by the members of Company A. In addition, the similarities and differences with newly arising and pre-pandemic crisis leadership and crisis management theories will be examined and applied to the case study. The identification of these theories and whether they may result in positive or unwanted outcomes will be noted.

1.3 Research Question and Objectives

The research question is: What leadership processes and behaviours can sustain performance during the current economic crisis within the case study company?

The following research objectives enable addressing the question:

- To critically review the literature pertaining to crisis leadership.
- To gather and analyse information on Company A leadership during the crisis.
- To identify leadership processes and behaviours perceived to achieve sustainable performance during the crisis and compare them to relevant theories.

The research is focused on human relations rather than tactical, operational responses.

1.4 Synopsis

The research focuses on the crisis leadership within the case study organisation, pertaining COVID-19 pandemic, from the epistemological perspective applying an interpretivist philosophy and abductive approach.

The literature review addressed in Part 2 concentrates on the first research objective and provides a broader understanding of the subject surrounding the crisis and crisis leadership, distinguishes between different stages of crisis and crisis response, and whether it correlates with a current situation of crisis and recognizes benefits or downsides of the certain leadership behaviours.

Part 3 discusses the rationale behind the methodology of the study, explaining the reasoning for chosen sample, data collection methods and data analysis, with the emphasis on the trustworthiness and credibility of the findings.

Part 4 presents and examines research findings with the focus on finding the meaning of the data by linking back to the reviewed literature discussed in Part 2.

Research conclusions drawn from the findings are represented in Part 5, outlining study limitations, recommendations for leadership of the case study organisation, and future research.

Part 6 presents a researcher's critical reflection on the dissertation process, emphasising the personal skills applied and acquired during the research journey.

2. Literature Review

This part addresses the first research objective to critically review the literature to gain a broader understanding of the crisis leadership concepts and theories prior to the COVID-19 pandemic and in the current context. The reviewed literature presents an array of topics, in relation to crisis and crisis leadership behaviours, derived from the academic journals, relevant academic books and articles, and includes recent publications exposing the complexity of the COVID-19 crisis and what leadership behaviours might be triggered by the crisis, and what is regarded as important in the organisational context.

The researcher accessed relevant literature through the following sources:

- The York St. John library specialist subject resources, business source premier
- The Google Scholar library
- The Scribd e-library (subscription)
- The McKinsey reports and articles (subscription)

The chapter begins with the definition of crisis and crisis in the extreme context, crisis stages, definition of leadership and crisis leadership behaviours, followed by a review of crisis leadership practices and behaviours under the COVID-19 pandemic and remote work practices. It also offers a conclusion at the end of the chapter.

2.1 Crisis Leadership

2.1.1 Defining Crisis

Derived from several scholars, Pearson and Clair refined and summarised the definition of crisis as:

"a low-probability, high-impact event that threatens the viability of the organization and is characterized by ambiguity of cause, effect, and means of resolution, as well as by a belief that decisions must be made swiftly" (1998, p. 60).

Even though the occurrences indicated in Table 1, some of which are viewed as extreme events, as they can "reach the threshold of 'intolerable magnitude'" (Hannah et al., 2009, p. 899) do not mention the situation of the pandemic, the offered definition appears to fit current context of the global pandemic and its "true ambiguity" (Courtney, Kirkland and

Viguerie, 1997). It goes beyond organisational crisis originated by the individual or a leadership's inactions or neglect.

Table 1: An Array of Organisational Crisis (based on Pearson and Clair, 1998, p. 60)

-Extortion -Hostile takeover -Product tampering -Vehicular fatality -Copyright infringement -Environmental spill -Computer tampering -Security breach -Executive kidnapping*	-Product/service boycotted -Work-related homicide* -National disaster that disrupts a major product or service* -National disaster that destroys organisational information base	-Information sabotage -Workplace bombing* -Terrorist attack* -Plant explosion* -Sexual harassment -Escape of hazardous material -Personal assault -Assault of customers	-Product recall -Counterfeiting -Natural disaster that destroys corporate headquarters* -Natural disaster that eliminates key stakeholders* -Bribery
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*Extreme event

Furthermore, the crisis has been conceptualised in terms of series of stages during which leaders should adhere to an appropriate response or course of action (Fink, 1986; Mitroff, 1994, 2005; González-Herrero and Pratt, 1996; Coombs, 2014; Le and Phi, 2021). While proposed stages indicated in Figure 1 vary, they appear to take their grassroots from the work of Fink (1986), as one of the earlier developers of the crisis models.

		COVID-19 Phases					
		Fink (1986)	Mitroff (1994)	González-Herrero and Pratt, (1996)	Cook (2015)	Coombs (2014)	Le and Phi, (2021)
STAGES	Pre Crisis	Prodromal - warning signals	Detection	Issue Management	Warning	Prevention Preparation	Pre-event and early symptoms
	Crisis Response	Acute – crisis accrue Chronic – crisis continue	Preparation Containment Recovery	Planning-prevention Crisis Decline	Responding Resuming Recovering	Response	Emergency phase Crisis phase
	Post Crisis	Resolution – crisis no longer a concern	Learning	Post Crisis	Restoring	Revision	Recovery phase “new normal” Resolution or

Figure 1: Stages of Crisis Comparison (based on Fink, 1986; Mitroff, 1994, 2005; González-Herrero and Pratt, 1996; Cook 2015; Coombs, 2014; Le and Phi, 2021).

Mentioned stages are often summarised as three general events surrounding the crisis: 1) pre-crisis; 2) crisis response; 3) post-crisis (Ndlela, 2019) and where strategic response changes from proactive to reactive depending on crisis dynamics (Le and Phi, 2021).

However, while presented stages are clearly defined, the magnitude of the novel crisis, its duration, impact, and unpredictable cyclical nature, possibly present a greater complexity. The duration of the stages may vary and be difficult to predict, depending on the industry and the country, as it is contingent upon the rate of infections and their recurrence (Le and Phi, 2021).

Moreover, the current crisis can be described as an extreme event as "it has been compared to the Second World War or the Great Depression in terms of its wide scope and broad impact" (Yan, 2020, p. 110). It presents a "control reducing threat" due to its abrupt nature beyond organisational power (Staw, Sandelands and Dutton, 1981) and can further be defined as a "sustained crisis" as its duration can last for a prolonged period (Parsons, 1996, p. 27).

Although definitions of the crisis have rather grim characteristics, it is important to point out that, according to some scholars, crisis possesses elements of dichotomy as it can also be viewed as an opportunity with unforeseen benefits or positive change which otherwise would not occur (Drennan and McConnell, 2007). Some examples of this phenomenon are currently observed in an unprecedented growth of digital industries, such as remote working platforms and tools, e-learning, e-commerce, to name a few (Somanas, 2020), as pandemic has forced a new way of life and new ways to conduct business.

2.1.2 Defining Leadership

While leadership is usually differentiated from the management (Kotter, 2011), it is still a synchronised union, especially in the context of the COVID-19 crisis, as leaders are pressed to deal with leading through the urgency of transformational change and managing business continuity simultaneously to ensure organisational survival and adapt to a "new normal" (Mather, 2020). However, the purpose of the study is to discuss crisis leadership behaviours with a specific focus on human relations rather than tactical, operational responses. Therefore, Yukl and Gardner's (2020) definition, where leadership is viewed as a

"process of influencing others to understand and agree about what needs to be done and how to do it, and the process of facilitating individual and collective efforts to accomplish shared objectives" (p. 26), appears as most appropriate as it focuses on the relational aspects between the leader and the followers. However, this is not to say that the leadership role purely belongs to an appointed leader as several members of the organisation often take on leadership roles by motivating their colleagues, taking the initiative using unspoken behaviours that inspire others (Yukl and Gardner, 2020).

Other important components of leadership that can be applied to crisis and non-crisis situations are accentuated by several scholars. According to Kotter (2011), leadership is about "coping with change" or "leading change [...] by developing the vision of the future" and "strategies for producing the change" (pp. 51-55). Similarly, Bass and Bass (2009) describe leaders as agents of change who are engaged and interactive with followers in a cooperative manner. Mitroff (2005) views crisis leadership as a proactive process where organisations strive to detect and prepare for crisis systematically, ahead of the event.

2.1.3 Crisis Leadership Behaviours

The study evaluates two opposites of the leadership approaches to the crisis through relationships with the followers: directive and participative.

Directive leadership exercises "command and control" (Owen et al., 2015) and represents a power relationship between the leader and the follower through reward or punishment of the led and can be linked to Theory X model (McGregor, 1960) or a top-down style of leadership. It can be observed in autocratic or directive leadership styles (Bass and Bass, 2009).

On the contrary, the participative leadership approach embodies a sense of "us-ness" (Haslam, Reicher and Platow, 2020) and related to Theory Y (McGregor, 1960), can also be described as "bottom-up" (Mantere and Vaara, 2008) or "middle-out" (Wooldridge, Schmid and Floyd, 2008). It is a partnership between the leader and the team, where the led are encouraged to express concerns, ideas and viewpoints, and their suggestions are considered important (Yukl and Lepsinger, 2004). This approach is reflected in the democratic or participative leadership styles (Bass and Bass, 2009).

According to Yukl and Gardner (2020), leaders of organisations exposed to crises, in the extreme context, are more likely to exercise directive and autocratic behaviours. This is where we are faced with a leadership dilemma as in a situation of crisis directive or autocratic leadership behaviours certainly have a short-term benefit, as it allows quick decision making and projects an image of certainty onto the leader. However, a number of studies have shown that "crisis-response efforts depend on many people" or followers, as it "demands coordination" in a participative manner through democratic and transformational leadership behaviours, as opposed to command and control (Boin and Hart, 2003, p. 547; Bussy and Paterson, 2012). This leadership dilemma will be discussed further in the context of Covid later in the chapter.

D'Auria and De Smet (2021) suggest that during a crisis characterised by uncertainty, leaders should go against their intuitive response to exercise the top-down style; they should instead foster collaborative, supportive and transparent behaviours by allowing team members and stakeholders to engage in a dialogue to "openly discuss ideas, questions, and concerns without fear of repercussions" (p. 4). Such an approach will likely enhance communication flow, information gathering and sharing, across the organisation's value chain and promote innovative behaviour (Amabile and Pratt, 2016; Temiz and Broo, 2020). Furthermore, Bass and Avolio's (1994) transformation leadership behaviours, known as the "Four I's", are change-oriented and allow leaders to inspire innovative thinking and build followers' confidence and ability to envision change by way of intellectual stimulation, inspirational motivation, idealised influence, or charisma and individual consideration (Bass and Avolio, 1994; Bass and Bass, 2009). In recent academic literature, transformational leadership behaviours are widely regarded in relation to the COVID-19 crisis, as they appear to best address crisis in extreme context by attending to followers' psychological needs of dealing with uncertainty, which is directly correlated with their job performance (Bluhm et al., 2021).

2.2 Crisis Leadership Under COVID-19 Pandemic and Remote Work Practices

While pre-COVID-19 crisis leadership theories present many similarities, there are also some differences as well as conceptual novelties. According to Tourish (2020), due to the COVID-19 crisis being such an unusual and unpredictable event, the mainstream leadership theories do not necessarily provide an effective solution in the current situation.

Wenzel and his colleagues (2021) suggest that although the range of strategic responses to a crisis is quite broad, the current situation presents a narrower scope of strategic responses, such as retrenchment, persevering, innovating, and exit. Therefore, it is plausible to assume that the leader-follower relationships might also be contingent upon the selected strategic response.

Others argue that the current crisis is resistant to traditional crisis response (Mysore and Usher, 2020). Mysore and Usher (2020) suggest that leaders of organisations should activate five responses: workforce protection to support employees' health and safety; supply chain stabilisation to ensure proper inventory management; customer engagement by attending to the needs of the customers; financial stress testing by modelling different cash-flow scenarios. All the responses should be activated through the network of teams with the "nerve-centre integration" as a centralised communication, information, and ideas generation hub (Mysore and Usher, 2020).

Working in teams entails social and task interdependence. Even though teams can still be hierarchical, such an approach indicates collaborative behaviour (Salas et al., 2007). However, the uniqueness of the COVID-19 crisis is not just in the sheer scale of the external ambiguity, it also creates a distance between the leader and the follower, either in teams or the organisation, due to the remote work practice (Hinojosa, Shaine and McCauley, 2020), which might have a psychological effect and can trigger a feeling of losing control over relational influence (McNulty and Marcus, 2020). Therefore, the presented situation goes beyond our typical pre-COVID virtual-team (VT) scenario as remote work brings additional challenges: many leaders are forced to transition into e-leaders, and many employees with families are turned into full-time babysitters.

Chamakiotis and his colleagues (2021) suggest that in order to develop high performing and creative VT, the newly transitioned e-leaders should develop engagement and trust, maintain appropriate work-life boundaries and promote digital well-being of their followers (Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021). Newman and Ford (2021) propose five steps to leading VTs during the COVID-19 crisis effectively. These include establishing and explaining new reality, sustaining the corporate culture and leader trustworthiness, upgrading leadership communication practices, encouraging shared leadership, and periodically aligning performance (Newman and Ford, 2021). All five steps encompass,

amongst other factors, a great deal of collaboration, trust, communication, empathy, clearly defined objective, creation of new routines and practices and shared leadership in order to encourage effective remote teamwork.

Furthermore, under the current conditions of this novel crisis, other critical elements emerge from recent academic literature. Those include the ability of the individual/leader to act with urgency and be decisive even if the decisions are not well-liked; communicate with transparency, without downplaying the threat and the scale of the crisis, reassess situations and adapt continuously; exude empathy; face mistakes head-on and accept responsibility (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020). The following sub-sections offer a review of the listed elements in more detail.

2.2.1 Act with Urgency

Trying to play down the crisis and failure to address it with urgency does not make the crisis go away: It delays an appropriate response and creates an even greater risk of instability (Spector, 2019). According to Kerrissey and Edmondson (2020), one of the important behaviours of effective crisis leaders is their ability to anticipate and act instead of reacting to the crisis, and to do so with urgency. While it is common for the leaders to gather as much information as possible before making difficult choices, in a situation of great uncertainty or an ambiguous threat (Roberto, Bohmer and Edmondson, 2006), such as COVID-19, leaders should go against those instincts and take decisions fast (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020) as failure to address any crisis with urgency might have a grim consequence (Spector, 2019).

Urgency under threat might suggest less time for the leader to collaborate with the followers or stakeholders, leading to the centralisation of power and decision making (Spector, 2019). Therefore, without much of the followers' participation, it will trigger an autocratic or directive style of leadership (Gill, 2011; Yukl and Gardner, 2020). Although, some studies indicate that control-reducing threat crisis activates a threat-rigidity effect, where such leadership behaviours are likely (Staw et al., 1981 cited by Stoker, Garretsen, and Soudis, 2019; Briker, Walter and Cole, 2021), and if the followers believe that the crisis is highly threatening, such behaviours are often welcomed by the followers, as it eliminates anxiety from the group (Spector, 2019). However, Anderson (2020) argues that "Leaders

should not navigate a crisis alone", as it is a stressful and emotionally consuming process, and should be able to delegate and empower others to contribute knowledge required at the point in time (p.12). Furthermore, according to Yukl's "Normative Decision Model", if a leader wants his or her decision to be accepted by the followers, even though their goals might not be aligned, the leader will still need to pursue a consultative or participative approach as opposed to autocratic (Yukl and Gardner, 2020). Thus, we can observe two contradictory ideas about appropriate leadership behaviour in addressing the crisis.

2.2.2 Communicate with Transparency

COVID or not, effective communication plays an essential role in crisis (Coombs, 2014; Ndlela, 2019). The ability of the leader to address the soon to be "elephant in the room" or, academically speaking, "known unknowns", without downplaying an imminent threat to the followers and stakeholders is critical (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020). Mysore and Usher (2020) argued that leaders should exude confidence and be realistic at the same time; behaviour referred to as "bounded optimism". Leaders should not be unrealistically optimistic by presenting a false reality (Mysore and Usher, 2020). Therefore, in crises, such communications should include messages of stability to the followers, if stability is possible.

Amberson (2020) highlights two elements contributing to establishing stability, which cover practical and emotional aspects of the followers' concerns. Leaders should address practical aspects concerned with the provision of tools and technology sufficient to function in the situation of crisis, and emotional aspect, by addressing job security as well as employee compensation. Being honest and transparent with the followers and explaining the meaning behind their decision making will effectively create credibility and trust in the leaders and will further bolster stability (Amberson, 2020).

Building upon Sullivan's (1998) work, Mayfields' (2018) Motivating Language Theory (MLT) proposes "meaning-making", "direction-giving", and "empathy" as three important components of effective communications, which will help a leader to keep followers motivated and engaged (p.14). The direction-giving, rather overused in comparison to the other two elements, is aimed at conveying organisational vision, objectives, tasks clarity, expectations and rewards to the followers. It gives clarity of what is expected from the follower. The meaning-making plays an important part in a formation of a culture, through

storytelling, by defining the purpose and meaning of the tasks through guidance (Mayfield and Mayfield, 2018), provides a shared understanding of the situation (König et al., 2020) and enhances followers proactivity (Binyamin and Brender-Ilan, 2018). The empathetic language includes messages of support and compassion. It goes beyond task-oriented behaviours (Mayfield and Mayfield, 2018) and has long been attributed to crisis management to help leaders and followers deal with emotional distress (Coombs, 2014). This is consistent with the recent study conducted by Caringal-Go et al. (2021), which indicates that one of the most regarded leadership behaviours in addressing the COVID crisis is supportive behaviour through "compassion and care" for the employees (p.635).

The Mayfields' (2018) MLT also resonates with Gillespie et al. (2020) "Practices for Preserving Employee Trust During Crises" with the addition of the empowerment of the employees and their fair treatment, where employees have a say in the decisions they are affected by and have a role in resolving the crisis. Furthermore, according to Hinojosa and her colleagues (2020), communication and transparency act as a bond rebuilder between the leader and followers during social distancing.

2.2.3 Reassess and Adapt Continuously

Although it might be tempting for the leaders to stick to the plan, in times of ambiguous crisis, continuous assessment of the situation of what is known and what is unknown will enable an organisation to adapt more rapidly to the newly arising challenges (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020). Relevant information is a key to the reassessment of the situation, and if a leader believes the information he or she possesses is sufficient, autocratic decision making is more likely in times of urgency. However, there is always a hazard that a leader might not be aware of all of the variables; therefore, a leader should engage in participative behaviour with the followers who hold relevant knowledge and experience (Yukl and Gardner, 2020). The network of teams with the "nerve-centre integration" would provide a diverse pool of knowledge and enable continuous reassessment and adaptation due to a centralised way of communication (Mysore and Usher, 2020).

2.2.4 Accept Responsibility and Promote Innovation

Nothing is certain in the situation of crisis. Therefore, not every action or decision will bring desired results. Moreover, performing under urgency decreases caution

significantly, and consequently, errors are more likely to occur (Evans, 2021). Therefore, the ability of the leader and the followers to reflect on the missteps, accept them and learn from them will make an organisation and its members innovative, resilient, and better prepared to navigate new challenges (Amberson, 2020). On the contrary, blame-shifting, punishment, and harsh criticism might jeopardise followers' desire to contribute to finding creative solutions to a crisis (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020), further weakening leader-follower relationships.

According to Johnson and Murray (2021), a crisis creates the best conditions to foster innovation as it takes an organisation away from normalcy bias by diverting organisational resources to combat the crisis. However, since this crisis is novel and unfamiliar, the organisational ability to respond to it using previous experiences or cognitive maps might not yield the desired result. Therefore, it amplifies the need for an organisation to innovate to stay resilient by creating alternative revenue streams, creative use of existing resources, and digitalisation.

Innovation begins with creativity, or an imaginative way of doing things better or differently, and is known to flourish in cooperative, collaborative work environments, where leaders play key roles in creating such environments by way of "intrinsic motivation" (Amabile and Pratt, 2016, p. 161). According to Amabile and Pratt (2016), although the leadership style plays an important role in organisational ability to innovate, there are other important variables, such as organisational culture, skills and knowledge of the employees, and allocation of resources. Therefore, it might be reasonable to assume that if leadership pivoted from participative to the directive approach during the early stages of a pandemic, a presence of other contributors geared toward innovation might still yield innovative behaviour from the followers. However, whether utilised or not, it is entirely up to the leader, as idea generation and idea implementation are enabled by the leader through positivity and rewards of the followers (Lim, Morse and Yu, 2020), through engagement with the followers by shifting gears toward more participative mindsets as "when it comes to innovation, the team really is greater than the sum of its parts" (Helton, 2020, p. 63).

2.3 Conclusion

Based on the reviewed literature, it is reasonable to assume that the COVID-19 pandemic presented new challenges to crisis leadership. While the urgency to address the crisis might trigger autocratic and directive behaviour, it does not appear to benefit the need for innovation in order to provide creative solutions to address an unfamiliar crisis. A collaborative approach, with a focus on communication and transparency, appears to play a central role in navigating a novel crisis (Mysore and Usher, 2020). Furthermore, according to Schaninger (2020), the leaders who are "still trying to hold on to top-down mandates" during COVID-19 crisis "could very quickly become the impediment rather than the solution" (Edmondson et al., 2020).

Even though some of the operational responses might exacerbate leader-follower relationships, as some unfavourable leadership actions cannot be avoided for an organisation to survive, clarity in decision making, meaning-making, empathetic and supportive behaviour appear to be important contributors in keeping followers motivated and engaged during the crisis (Mather, 2020). Furthermore, errors in decision making can be reduced through the greater pull of expertise and information sharing, which again emphasises collaborative behaviour (Yukl and Gardner, 2020).

While crisis stages and strategic responses vary, depending on the country or industry, the reviewed leadership behaviours seem to be regarded as important in addressing the COVID-19 crisis. However, it is unclear how long this practice can withstand this unusual situation and if reviewed behaviours and practices will be sufficient for the "remote" or "virtual" leaders in the long term.

The assessment of leadership behaviours and their effect on leader-follower dynamics during different crisis stages, through fieldwork done in the case study organisation, addressed the research question and objectives. The methodology used in the research is discussed in the following chapter.

3. Research Methodology

This part focuses on the rationale behind selected research philosophy, approach and strategy, and the reasons behind the selection are specified. It explains participants' recruitment strategy, data collection methods, data analysis, pretesting, ethical issues, validity and bias.

3.1 Research Philosophy and Design

This study follows Saunders et al. (2015) research onion framework. The red circles in Figure 2 indicate the selected strategy.

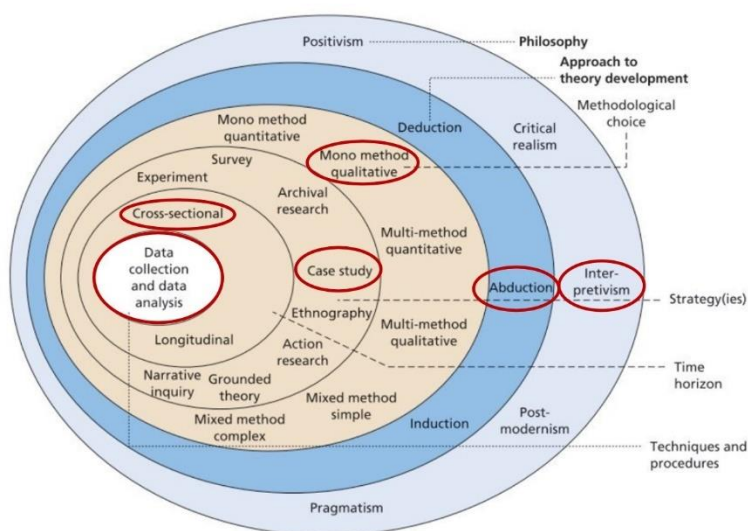


Figure 2: Research Strategy through the "Research onion" (based on Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015, p. 124)

During an initial appraisal using the "Heightening your Awareness of your Research Philosophy" (HARP) self-assessment tool (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015; Appendix A), the researcher scored the highest in a "Critical Realism" category, as a personal philosophy. However, the research question and research objectives suggest adopting the "interpretivism" research philosophy, as it explores subjects important to the participants with the focus on recollection of the "lived experience" and their perception (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015, pp. 141). Moreover, the researcher is engaged in collaborative behaviour with the practitioners by linking their perceived understanding of what is appropriate in the studies phenomena with theoretical knowledge (Fisher and Buglear, 2010). Therefore, the interpretivism research philosophy is chosen as most appropriate.

Furthermore, the research adopts an "abductive" approach, as it serves as a good middle ground between "deductive" and "inductive" approaches. While the subject, in a general context, is not new, the conditions under which researched phenomena develop are. Therefore, moving between the data collection and theories by establishing important themes better supports the aim to explain causal relationships between various hypotheses and studied phenomena (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015).

This research applies a "case study" method, which is often used to assess crisis leadership response (Bowers, Hall, and Srinivasan, 2017), as the aim of the research is not to develop a theory by enquiring into the phenomena within the population at large, but rather to study the phenomena within the organisation, and relate it to existing theories.

3.2 Data Collection Method

The study applies the "qualitative method" of data collection (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015, p. 136) through semi-structured interviews. Even though the semi-structured interview method has its drawbacks as the sample size is naturally smaller, as opposed to a questionnaire that can reach a wider audience, the chosen method allows a set of compatible responses and allows rich data to emerge, further revealing new and more in-depth insights to the subject (Wisker, 2008).

The researcher adopted the "academic – a harmless judge" role, as by being an employee in the case study, the organisation researcher does not want to pose any threat or be seen as overly intrusive (Fisher and Buglear, 2010, pp 48-49). And while, according to Fisher and Buglear (2010), the downside of a chosen role might imply that an organisation will not allocate much of a priority to the study, approvals to conduct the research were granted by the company leadership swiftly, and targeted members were enthusiastic about participating, even with the interviews scheduled outside of working hours.

Participants (P) included twelve members of the case study organisation, a "purposive sample" and a "maximum variation" sample (Gray, 2014, pp 217-219). They were selected based on the researcher's judgment using the following criteria:

- good communicators
- capable of being reflective
- represented variation across departments

- represented different countries of origin
- different lengths of time with the organisation
- different genders

The study sample included 29% of the personnel, as indicated in Tables 3 and 4, whom the studied phenomena directly impacted and were employed by the organisation before and during the COVID-19 pandemic. Table 4 gives details showing the range of participants but, for ethical reasons, does not provide participants codes.

Table 3: Study Sample Overview

Organisational infrastructure	Impacted Population	Sample Size	Sample Size: Representation of the Total Population
CEO	1	1	100%
Business Development (Researcher)	1		
Sales	20	6	30%
Marketing	4	3	75%
Training	4	1	25%
Procurement	4	1	25%
Finance	1		
HR and Legal	1		
Logistics (Outsourced)	6		
TOTAL	42	12	29%

Table 4: Study Sample Details

Function	Gender M/F	Nationality	Tenure with the organisation	Invitation sent	Agreed	Date of the interview	Duration of the interview (time recorded)	Interview method
Marketing	F	French	5 Y	09.06.2021	Yes	12.06.2021, 10am	1 h 11 min	MS Teams, recorded
CEO	M	Lebanese	16 Y	20.06.2021	Yes	26.06.2021, 9.30am	38 min	MS Teams, recorded
Marketing	F	Lithuanian	4 Y	09.06.2021	Yes	19.06.2021, 3pm	42 min	MS Teams, recorded
Marketing	F	Philippines	16 Y	09.06.2021	Yes	29.06.2021, 8pm	45 min	MS Teams, recorded
Sales	M	Armenian	3 Y	09.06.2021	Yes	19.06.2021, 12pm	50 min	MS Teams, recorded
Sales	M	Egyptian	3 Y	09.06.2021	Yes	16.06.2021, 7pm	42 min	MS Teams, recorded
Sales	M	Syrian	3 Y	09.06.2021	No	Alternative participants were invited instead		
Sales	M	Romanian	4 Y	09.06.2021	Yes	18.06.2021, 9am	53 min	MS Teams, recorded
Sales	F	Lebanese	11 M	09.06.2021	Yes	19.06.2021, 9am	32 min	MS Teams, recorded
Sales	F	Indonesian	11 M	09.06.2021	Yes	19.06.2021, 10am	50 min	MS Teams, recorded
Training	F	Scottish	6 Y	09.06.2021	Yes	18.06.2021, 11am	50 min	MS Teams, recorded
Procurement	F	Pakistani	5 Y	09.06.2021	Yes	19.06.2021, 5pm	43 min	MS Teams, recorded
Training	F	Kenyan	4 Y	21.06.2021	No			
Sales	M	Syrian	3 Y	21.06.2021	Yes	28.06.2021, 7.30pm	47 min	MS Teams, recorded

Interview invitations were sent to the twelve targeted participants. One of the participants did not respond to the invitation and was replaced by another candidate, as

indicated in Table 4. The thirty minutes to one-hour interviews, forty-seven minutes on average, were "conducted over a short period of time", which implies a "cross-sectional" approach (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015, p. 200), one on one, through virtual meetings using Microsoft Teams application.

The interviews included six core questions indicated in Appendix B, which were designed to explore three data topics or domains (Braun and Clarke, 2020): the challenges employees faced during the crisis, how the organisation reacted to the crisis, and thoughts on the leadership during the crisis, the follow-up questions and probing open-ended questions based on the interviewees' responses. Proposed questions were reviewed by a dissertation supervisor and amended, taking into consideration the supervisor's feedback. Upon completion of the pilot interview, findings of which were also integrated into the research, further amendments were made with the guidance of the dissertation supervisor. The formation of the questions, using Appreciative Inquiry for some, and Behavioural Interview methods, provided an ability to soften the edges, as it was a sensitive subject for some of the participants. Furthermore, methods combined with no value judgment, criticism of any kind or leading questions kept the researcher impartial and away from any possible tensions with the colleagues. All the interviews were audio-recorded, following the interviewee's written consent.

Additionally, two of the participants (P9 and P10) were employed by different organisations during the early "crisis response" stage and were later transferred under Company A's employment. Therefore, information collected from those two interviewees produced a comparative set of data in addition to subject pertaining theories, where leadership response widely differed from Company A.

3.3 Primary Data Analysis

Data was analysed using Braun and Clarke (2019) reflexive approach to Thematic Analysis (TA). It differs from other schools of TA such as "codebooks" or "code reliability", as it is fully qualitative research which is reflected in the chosen philosophy and methods with the aim "to provide a coherent and compelling interpretation of the data, grounded in the data" and where the patterns of shared meanings produced the themes and not the other way around (p.848; Braun and Clarke, 2020).

The researcher applied the "six-phases" of the reflexive TA approach (Braun et al., 2019), which included data familiarisation by listening to the recorded interviews and making a partial transcription of the participants' responses and connecting it to a gained theoretical knowledge. The next phase was "code generation" by moving between data and theory and finding meanings of the data. Generated codes enabled the construction of themes by combining codes with similar meanings or promoting some of the codes to themes at the third phase (Appendix E), which later allowed the researcher to tell a story about the data and address the research question. At the fourth and fifth phases of revisiting and further defining themes, the researcher obtained feedback from the dissertation supervisor to ensure there was no theme overlap or conceptual disconnect, that presented data was sufficient to address the research question, and to move to the final stage of writing the analysis by connecting the findings with subject pertaining theories in either descriptive or an exploratory manner (Braun et al., 2019).

3.4 Research Ethics

Ahead of the study, the researcher approached the leadership of the case study organisation, and its legal counsel, to obtain approval to conduct the research by sharing the research brief, interview questions and example of the consent form. This is consistent with the term referred to by Easterby-Smith et al. (2019) as "formal access". The formal approval was followed by an email to all the company employees stating that if anyone desires to participate, they are free to do so upon the researcher's enquiry.

It was important to the researcher that all the interviewees were comfortable participating. Therefore, it was crucial to cover all the ethical issues that might arise by following Bell's and Bryman's key principles of research ethics aimed to protect the research participants and integrity of the research community (Bell's and Bryman's, 2007 cited by Easterby-Smith et al. 2019). The participants were given a research briefing (Appendix C) based on Fisher and Buglear (2010) "example of the participant information sheet" (pp.76-77) and consent form (Appendix D), insured confidentiality, anonymity, and respect to privacy, and freely gave informed consent to participate with the right to withdraw from the research at any time. Furthermore, participants' names, job titles and departments were coded and securely stored separately from the interview notes or recordings.

The researcher has followed ethical guidelines specified by York St. John University, based on which university approval for the research has been granted (Appendix F).

3.5 Validity and Bias

According to Richards (2020), there are no standardised ways to challenge the validity of the qualitative research statistically, but rather through "credibility, transferability and dependability". Therefore, it can be considered appropriate or valid if the offered argument in addressing the research question is "properly rooted in data" through in-depth questioning and logically linked to a sound conclusion (Richards, 2020, p.177).

Furthermore, according to Easterby-Smith and his colleagues (2019), it is important to point out that due to the researcher being an employee of the case study organisation, one should recognise the possibility of internal politics, which might not be obvious but could lead to withholding of information, and a lack of objectivity in judgment, or personal bias. Therefore, regardless of the close professional relationships with the participants, the researcher should be sensitive to the context, and as pointed out earlier, should not pose any value judgment or lead participants toward certain assumptions. However, it is also important to point out that while the data produced by the researcher is, in any case, subjective, as it is subject to the researcher's interpretation and creativity, it should not be considered as a "potential threat to knowledge production" but rather as a resource, as themes and meanings are "analytical outputs" derived from data, and are "context-bound" (Braun and Clarke, 2019, p. 591).

4. Research Findings and Discussion

This part presents and examines research findings obtained from the interviews to address the third research objective, which is to gain an understanding of identified leadership processes perceived to achieve sustainable performance during the crisis within the case study organisation and compare it to relevant literature, with the focus on finding the meaning of the data.

The research participants are referred to as follows: Researcher (R); Leader X (LX); Interview participant (P): Without salary (WS): With half salary (HS).

4.1 Presentation of Findings

During the interview process, it was discovered that four employees were still receiving part salaries during the first three months of the crisis, while seven of the participants were forced to take unpaid leave for three months. The researcher observed that the emotional distress levels during the interview process were lower in those who were paid. Qualitative data from the interview transcripts of twelve participants, which included eleven employees and LX, was analysed, and themes were built from codes and from quotes (Appendix E). Developed themes and frequency of its appearance are summarised in Table 5.

Table 5: Interview Themes

Theme Name	How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)	How many participants mentioned it
Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.	15	5
Effective personal safety measures reduce worry during the pandemic.	1	1
Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.	15	7
Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.	10	6
Innovating is the way to sustain the business.	19	11
-Sub theme: Innovation promotes new learning and vice versa.	3	3
Job security is of the highest priority for the employees during the crisis.	16	9
Need for clear and transparent communication instil sense of stability.	36	12
Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.	19	7
Remote teamwork does not have the same ease of communication.	4	4
Survival of the business as a top priority.	11	5
The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.	17	8
The new normal presents tighter financial control.	7	3

The representation of two different groups of employees, paid and unpaid, will be exemplified in relation to the developed theme. In addition, two of the participants, P9 and P10, were employed by a different organisation (Company B) during the early "crisis response" stage. Therefore, information collected from those two interviewees is also used as a comparative set of data in addition to subject pertaining theories later in the chapter, where leadership response widely differed from Company A.

4.1.1 Theme 1: Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response

Theme 1, as indicated in Table 6, was mentioned by seven interviewees, and represents 58% of participants. While six of the employees mentioned Theme 1, one to three times, LX talked about it seven times during the interview which indicates a greater significance of the subject to LX.

Table 6: Theme 1

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
2	10	7	19	2	4	1	7

The leadership of the organisation did not anticipate the scale of the crisis. None of the employees expected a full closure of the organisation and were not ready to handle the situation when the lockdowns to stop the spread of the virus were announced by the regional government. The leadership of the organisation did not have plans or strategies that were drawn on how to continue the business at the early stages of the crisis, which included: alternative revenue streams, appropriate communication with the employees, buyers, and suppliers, so the organisation proceeded with the retrenchment.

"It was damage control. Turnover will not come, finish. So what can we do? Are we ready for something else? No! So, limit the consequences on the company because the company had to run one day" (LX).

"In the beginning, there was no organised plan for what we will do. Everything was messed up. [...] So, the impact was honestly.... In the first two months, it was a disaster: cutting costs, cutting salaries" (P6WS).

Conversely, Company B appears to be prepared and seemed to respond to the crisis swiftly and effectively.

“Everything went very smoothly. We were able to adapt very quickly, online and everything” (P9HS).

4.1.2 Theme 2: Survival of the business as a top priority

This theme was mentioned by five participants and appears to have more significance to LX, with seven mentions, versus only one mention from the other four interviewees.

Table 7: Theme 2

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
1	3	7	11	1	3	1	5

The leadership of the organisation saw the temporary closure of the business as the only option to safeguard the company, while the employees regarded the closure as a disaster and missed opportunity. Even though the business was not operational, the leadership managed to renegotiate more favourable credit terms with the suppliers, which eased a financial burden during the closure.

"What was important to you?" (R) "It is to maintain the business after the crisis and to maintain my team. I had two choices, either I keep everybody without salary for three months, or I start to get rid of people" (LX).

"We talked to the suppliers to extend our credit terms. Suppliers were very supportive of that" (LX).

4.1.3 Theme 3: Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively

Theme 3 was mentioned by five interviewees, including LX. The leading number of mentions (nine) belongs to two of the middle management, which makes it more significant to them, while two of the employees with the lower seniority mentioned it only once.

Table 8: Theme 3

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
1	10	4	15	1	3	1	5

LX did not consult company management before deciding to close for three months. There was no strategy meeting, no brainstorming, or any discussion about what could be done. Senior and middle management took the initiative and submitted various proposals on how to manage the crisis more effectively, but it was disregarded. However, during the interview, LX admitted that brainstorming at the early stages of the crisis would have been helpful.

"Damage control was based on the cash we had. This kind of decision, I am the only one who can take it" (LX).

"Maybe we could have some brainstorming, get more ideas at earlier stages" (LX).

"There is so much we could do. I feel that there should have been a strategy meeting" (P11WS).

"I felt very bad! My ideas are not valid, and decisions are like 'one men show'. We just following what we are instructed to do. Most of our proposals were turned down, and I feel bad" (P3WS).

4.1.4 Theme 4: The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment

This theme was dominant amongst employees without salaries as all seven of them mentioned it. The participant who appeared to be in a most distress during the interview, and ended up crying, mentioned it five times, while other participants' mentions varied from one to four.

Table 9: Theme 4

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
	16	1	18		7	1	8

While Leader X decided to keep some of the low paid employees on half salary, the leadership's withdrawal from taking the initiative to gain an understanding of the financial struggles of the employees created a great deal of frustration, hurt and demotivation, and weakened loyalty amongst the employees who were forced to take three months of unpaid leave. LX did not seem to understand the severity of the employees' struggles.

"Maybe we did not say it, but everybody understood that we are in this together" (LX).

"I asked them to give me a little money to reimburse later, and it was denied" (P1WS).

"I thought it was harsh. It was very inhumane" (P4WS).

"No, nothing was well! From the beginning, we were unclear, anxious, panicking" (P3WS).

"The company just left us for three months and longer [...] I did feel a bit angry and a bit hurt that it was an inappropriate thing to do to people who worked for them".

"They don't care about you. You are just a number. They want to save the company, but I am just a number, so why would I try anything" (P11WS).

4.1.5 Theme 5: Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability

Theme 5 was the most talked about and represents a widely-held opinion, as it was discussed by all twelve interviewees, and had thirty-six mentions, which is the highest in comparison to other themes. Mentions per participant varied from one to six.

Table 10: Theme 5

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
10	24	2	36	4	7	1	12

The team was concerned by the lack of communication and the reasoning behind the actions taken by the leadership. Employees were in a state of panic and uncertainty, and were gathering information from other colleagues on the situation in the region. Once unpaid employees returned to work on 50% salary, they still did not understand when their remuneration package would be re-established in full and eventually confronted the

leadership to clarify. On the contrary, the leadership has informed the employees who were on 50% pay throughout the crisis, that the salary reduction would last for one year, and that knowledge gave them the sense of reassurance of stability.

Furthermore, company suppliers were not informed about the closure at the early stages of the crisis and did not understand why employees of the organisation stopped replying to their emails.

"We had a monthly letter sent to them [employees]. Maybe, this thing [communication], we should do better, to talk more" (LX).

"I never heard anything from him [LX] for like six weeks. Everything just completely stopped, no communication" (P11WS).

"Organisation gave us nothing at that time, so it was very difficult to face my team [retail team] to answer to them. We were panicking if we were going to continue or not" (P14WS).

"We signed that we would get 50% salary for one year, but we will keep our jobs" (P12HS). "So you had clarity?" (R) "Yes" (P12HS).

"I was receiving calls from suppliers asking me questions. I did not know what to answer to the suppliers. They were surprised that we completely closed the offices" (P3WS).

Another example of a good practice was demonstrated by Company B, as employees had full clarity of what was happening, and clear communication on what to expect.

"It was really such a protective moment in such a difficult time. In the first week itself, we were already informed what is going to happen. We had clarity" (P10HS).

4.1.6 Theme 6: Job security is of the highest priority for the employees during the crisis

This theme was mentioned by nine interviewees and represent a subject of great significance for the Company A employees.

Table 11: Theme 6

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
5	11		16	2	7		9

One of the top concerns for nine of the employees was their financial survival as, regionally, there is no governmental social support system for expatriates. Hence, the concerns about job security were dominant. Furthermore, due to poor communication, there was no certainty about future employment with the organisation, especially amongst the employees on unpaid leave. Even though the employees went through a financial hardship, they were grateful to retain their jobs after the crisis subsided.

"What was important to you at the early stages of the crisis? (R)

"To feel safe, finance wise. The most threatening thing was stability" (P6WS).

"Personally, that I am not made redundant. That I still have my job" (P3WS).

"We maintained our jobs. We are still working to date. I am very thankful and grateful that I have managed to survive with my family" (P14WS).

4.1.7 Theme 7: Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities

Theme 7 was mentioned by seven participants, including LX with three mentions. That might indicate a subject of a moderate to high significance not just for the employees but also for LX.

Table 12: Theme 7

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
2	10	3	15	1	5	1	7

While the leadership did provide basic financial support for the low-paid employees, which shows empathy, the rest of the team was left to deal with their emotional and financial struggles on their own, which made them feel neglected, unappreciated and demotivated. While P14WS received some financial support upon request, requests from P1WS and P4WS were denied.

"We favoured people with a small salary" (LX).

"I was bothered by non-communication. Or to ask us, are you ok with it? Is everything fine?" (P1WS).

"I felt the company did not value you as a person. They did not check to see and ask how is the situation." "I think I cried every day for about a month. I went into a bit of shock, and I felt very alone" (P11WS).

"They did not give any support. It saddened me. It is sad. I did not expect this from the management [...] he (LX) did not think of his employee's welfare at the time" (P4WS).

"Taking care of the people will produce more. [...] People will not leave the organisation because of the money, people leave when they don't feel appreciated" (P8WS).

In contrast, Company B leadership made sure to personally understand how their employees were doing, which made a positive impact on employees' emotional wellbeing.

"One of the company owners called me asking me how you are. It was very important for me. I felt safe. I was really taken care of emotionally" (P10HS).

4.1.8 Theme 8: Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business

This theme indicates a moderate importance as it was mentioned by six participants, although not by LX. The highest number of mentions (five) came from one team member, with half salary, who was operating in Qatar and was closely working with LX at a time.

Table 13: Theme 8

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
7	3		10	3	3		6

Two months into the pandemic, leadership recognised that there were alternative ways to generate revenue, as the team in Qatar continued their operation and frequently communicated their ideas and success stories with LX. Thereafter, LX gave a directive to the team to start generating ideas for the rest of the region. However, while the UAE team appears to be very collaborative with good information flow, which produced some great results, it is unclear if success stories from Qatar were communicated or implemented elsewhere.

"They said that we need to start selling. All the team was exchanging ideas without senior management" (P3WS).

"More meetings to set up a new way to approach the business. All info I brought from the market, we discussed immediately" (P8WS).

"Did you have a chance to hear what other area managers are doing for a different brand?" (R) "Actually, not much. We had only one meeting with the countries, with a team" (P5HS).

4.1.9 Theme 9: Innovating is the way to sustain the business

Theme 9 appeared to be of a great importance to the participants as it was mentioned by eleven interviewees, including LX. Although the sub theme: Innovation promotes new learning and vice versa, was only mentioned by three participants, it can still be viewed as important in relation to the main theme.

Table 14: Theme 9

	How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
Theme 9	5	11	3	19	4	6	1	11
-Sub theme		3		3		3		3

Although there was no directive from the leadership to create a new way of doing things during the first two months of the crisis, team members were taking the initiative by proposing new ideas to generate revenue, address training and marketing needs, some of which materialised at a later stage, and some did not as it required an additional resource. During this process, team members acquired new skills and knowledge as a business pivot into the digital space.

"During unpaid leave, there were no activities whatsoever. It was just me trying to come up with the solution to come back to work early" (P8WS).

"During the third month, we start applying/facilitating online. For the company, it was completely new" (P14WS).

"We were doing masterclasses online, social media, advises and training - Approaching end consumers directly. We have not done this before" (P3WS).

"I had to study social media. That's the best side of it" (P4WS).

4.1.10 Theme 10: The new normal presents tighter financial control

This theme was mentioned by three participants, five of the mentions came just from one interviewee in middle management, which might place this theme into a category of lower significance.

Table 15: Theme 10

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
1	6		7	1	2		3

Upon the reopening, LX took complete control over every aspect of the business. As a result, operational expenses, including stocking orders, training and marketing, were cut to a bare minimum which, on one hand, was challenging for the team but, on the other, made them more creative and promoted more collaboration amongst the team members.

"There is a big difference. He is somehow stricter in terms of budget, expenses, how he deals with people" (P4WS).

"We are always brainstorming with a team. The manager told us to cut your cost, "this is too much", so the team finds a way how to" (P4WS).

"Double and triple check [more control]. The ordering process was delayed and reduced quantity, which impacted the business" (P8WS).

4.1.11 Theme 11: Remote teamwork does not have the same ease of communication

Although this theme does not appear as significant, as it only has four mentions, we should consider that there was not a lot of remote teamwork to speak of, as most of the business was not operational during the first two months of crisis, it still plays an important role in understanding communication process and practices when working remotely.

Table 16: Theme 11

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
1	3		4	1	3		4

While partially remote collaboration is not new for team members, utterly remote work does not appear as productive as face-to-face communication. Despite these conditions, the team was able to transition and adapt to the remote work environment by designing, training, marketing, and sales activations later into the pandemic.

"When you are face to face meeting, it works in a better way, but It was the best tool in hand for us to use" (P14WS).

"For the business meetings, it was ok. For sales training, I found it difficult as productivity is not the same. [...] Online, it was just like a brick wall between you and the person" (P8WS).

4.1.12 Theme 12: Effective personal safety measures reduce worry during the pandemic

Even though this theme had only one mention, during the time of pandemic it might be considered as a good sign, as there were no concerns expressed in relation to personal safety.

Table 17: Theme 12

How many times it was mentioned (across all interviews)				How many participants mentioned it			
With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total	With half salary	Without salary	Leader X	Total
	1		1		1		1

Due to effective personal safety measures being a part of the government mandate in the region, none of the interviews were concerned about their health and safety as Company A complied with government regulations.

"I felt safe because they started imposing social distancing and gave us a choice to work from home. There is always hand sanitisers and a pile of masks" (P1WS).

4.2 Discussion

The developed themes represented in the earlier chapter can be connected, as demonstrated in Figure 3.

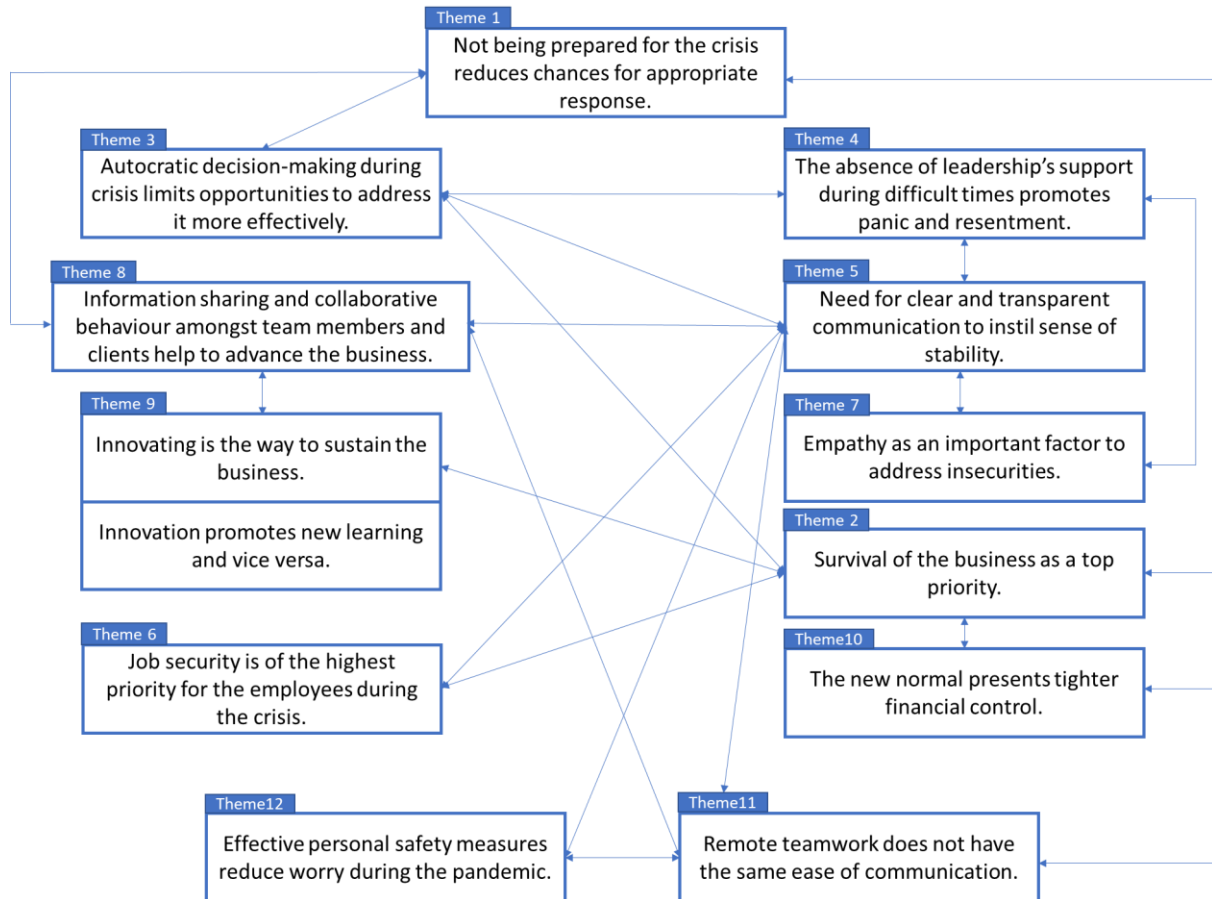


Figure 3: Connection of Themes

Theme 5 has most connections, linking it to seven other themes and can be viewed as one of the most central. This is also reflected in the interview data as it was discussed by all participants with the highest number of mentions. Two of the second highest themes, with five connections each, are Themes 1 and 2, and while it did not have the highest number of mentions, it was a top priority in the leadership agenda.

Even though the connections of themes presented in Figure 3 could be argued, they seem to create an interconnected network of ideas, practices, and behaviours which might be important in the context of COVID-19 crisis leadership as demonstrated in the following chapter.

4.2.1 Organisational Preparedness and Survival

Company A was not prepared for the crisis (Theme 1) and did not recognise "pre-event and early symptoms" (Le and Phi, 2021) or address the crisis at the "pre-crisis" stage (Ndlela, 2019). Therefore, they did not act with urgency (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020), which seems to have reduced their chances of appropriate response (Theme 1). However, the leadership did react with urgency at the "emergency phase" (Le and Phi, 2021) by employing an immediate cost-cutting strategy to preserve the business in the long term, as it was a top priority for LX (Theme 2).

The deployed strategy appears to be something of a hybrid between retrenchment and exit strategy (Wenzel, Stanske and Lieberman, 2021), as while a partial operation continued in Qatar, all business activities in the UAE, KSA and Kuwait completely stopped for a period of two months, and were partially reinstated at the later stage of the pandemic. The LX's decision to employ such a strategy was autocratic (Bass and Bass, 2009), as none of the senior management was consulted prior to the announcement (Theme 3). This is in line with Yukl and Gardner (2020) theory that leaders exposed to crises in the extreme context are more likely to behave in such a manner as centralisation of power allows quick decision making when dealing with urgency under threat (Spector, 2019). Here we are presented with a leadership dilemma, as although it is reasonable to assume that the lack of preparedness (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020) and an absence of collaborative behaviour between the leader and the team (Theme 8) might have resulted in extreme response measures (Amberson, 2020), given the imminent threat, leadership had to act quickly by exercising top-down style (Spector, 2019) in order to preserve the business (Theme 2).

It is also important to point out that Company A was out of its comfort zone, not just by dealing with the transformational change but also doing it with a dispersed workforce. The leadership of the organisation did not address remote work practices in any special way (Theme 11). Even when the crisis emerged and remote work became inevitable, there was no establishment of new policies or procedures, no enquiries into the team's experience working from home, no alignment of VTs or any specific instructions related to virtual practices (Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021; Newman and Ford, 2021) aside from the assigned weekly meetings with LX. Employees of the organisation seem to adjust to a new routine the best way they could and did manage to share leadership responsibilities

(Newman and Ford, 2021) in running different projects. Perhaps the lack of strategy to address a dispersed workforce resulted in employees' remarks that remote teamwork has a diminished ease of communication. It might also be reasonable to suggest that if the leadership of the organisation had adhered to Newman's and Ford's (2021) Five Steps, the severity of the drama and panic associated with the leadership's crisis response could have been avoided. Hence, we cannot discard the fact that company leadership might not have been prepared to transition into e-leadership in a blink of an eye and could not envision how full operation, coordination, allocation of resources could have been done virtually (Newman and Ford, 2021; Theme 11). Therefore, we can again emphasise that not being prepared for the crisis, or acting with urgency, reduces chances for appropriate response (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020; Theme 1).

4.2.2 The Importance of Effective Crisis Communication

LX did not use a consultative or collaborative approach in addressing the crisis (Theme 3). Therefore, employees of the organisation were saddened by the announcement of the temporary closure and exhibited signs of resistance (Yukl and Gardner, 2020). Lack of transparency (Theme 5) caused a broken bond within the leader-follower relationship (Hinojosa, Shaine and McCauley, 2020).

Furthermore, leadership did not address practical or emotional concerns of the employees without salaries (Theme 4; Theme 7), which left them in an unstable state, constantly worrying about their jobs (Theme 6) and the future of the organisation (Amberson, 2020). On the contrary, the lower-paid employees were given clarity about the situation (Theme 5). They knew that they would be on half salary for a year and that their jobs were safe (Theme 6): they felt more stable and secure (Amberson, 2020). The leadership rarely deployed the Mayfields' (2018) MLT practices. The meaning-making and direction-giving started to appear upon reopening, and the empathetic or supportive behaviour was only applied to the handful of personnel which kept unpaid employees in the state of panic and emotional distress throughout the pandemic (Mayfields, 2018; Coombs, 2014; Caringal-Go et al., 2021), and without leadership's support they felt abandoned (Theme 4). The need for clear and transparent communication (Theme 5) was one of the most discussed during the interviews, and it was directly associated with the sense of stability amongst the employees (Amberson, 2020). Employees wanted to be involved, they wanted to contribute

to the resolution of the crisis, and by not being given such an opportunity, they were losing trust (Gillespie et al. 2020).

The earlier demonstrated example of good practice by Company B, where two of the interview participants were working at the time, such that P9 and P10 had full clarity of what was happening and clear communication on what to expect (Theme 5). The employees felt secure and supported, engaged and proactive, which promoted stability amongst team members (Amberson, 2020).

4.2.3 Promote Collaboration to Foster Innovative Behaviour

According to LX, he continually gathered information on the crisis development from external sources. LX believed that the information he possessed was sufficient, therefore, he did not use the internal pool of knowledge and expertise during the first two months of the crisis, which again emphasises autocratic decision making (Yukl and Gardner, 2020). Into the third month of crisis, LX started listening to the team's suggestions and proposals (Theme 8), at which point the business started to reopen. Upon reopening, the leadership of the organisation, although exercising tighter control (Theme 10), did engage in more collaborative behaviour, and employees began to work on new, creative ways to address the business (Amabile and Pratt, 2016; Theme 8). This indicates the shift from a "top-down" leadership approach (Bass and Bass, 2009) to a "bottom-up" (Mantere and Vaara, 2008) or a "middle-out" (Wooldridge, Schmid and Floyd, 2008) style, although, still, with a great deal of control (Owen et al., 2015) in the financial aspect.

In addition, the third month into the crisis, LX recognised that crisis does provide an opportunity to innovate (Johnson and Murray, 2021) as it creates prospects for new brand acquisitions, which represent innovating strategy, it moved the organisation to strategy renewal (Wenzel, Stanske and Lieberman, 2021; Theme 9).

As mistakes are common while performing under urgency (Evans, 2021), during the interview, LX admitted that the communication and collaboration with the team and suppliers were rather poor (Theme 5; Theme 8). Later into the crisis, LX also recognised, by listening to his team members, that the alternative revenue streams and opportunities to conduct the business can be developed with the use of existing resources. Although he did

not admit his missteps to the team (Amberson, 2020), he supported the team to start implementing some of their ideas (Theme 9).

Although LX still applied a directive leadership style and the team was frustrated that they had lost so much time, they have worked in a highly collaborative manner (Theme 8), sharing ideas, implementing changes, and subsequently took on leadership roles in driving innovation (Yukl's et al. 2020). However, while collaborative behaviour and teamwork was a norm before the COVID crisis, it is important to note that the team's creativity and innovative behaviour was mostly motivated by the desperate need to return to work and earn an income (Theme 6), which, in effect, became their extrinsic motivator (Amabile and Pratt, 2016). Even though we can only observe minor signs of intrinsic motivation, such as learning new digital skills, which is considered to be important for the encouragement of creative behaviour (Amabile and Pratt, 2016), the team was able to come up with a variety of innovative solutions to address this transformational change by learning and adapting throughout the process (Theme 9).

4.3 Conclusion

In this chapter we have reviewed twelve themes developed from the case study data. The network of themes allowed to tell a story (Braun et al., 2019), and connect the findings by moving between the data and the theory (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015) which allowed to explain relationships between the data and various hypothesis. The conclusions and recommendations derived from the discussion of findings are presented in the next chapter.

5. Conclusions and Recommendations

This dissertation asks the question, "What leadership processes and behaviours can sustain performance during the current economic crisis within the case study company?" Answers were sought by searching the literature pertaining to crisis leadership and analysing the information gathered on Company A leadership by developing themes that identified integrated leadership processes perceived to achieve sustainable performance during the crisis, based on which recommendations are given.

This part offers research-based conclusions and presents recommendations for the consideration for the Company A leadership. It points out some general study limitations and a basis for future research.

Based on the performed assessment, recommendations were addressed using the 5Ws1H problem-solving method (Ram, 2018).

What: required improvement.

Why: reason for performing the assignment.

When: start of the assignment and its frequency.

Where: place of execution, Company A Head Quarters (HQ).

Who: stakeholders.

How: method of execution.

5.1 Conclusion and Recommendations

The COVID-19 crisis was indeed an extreme event (Pearson and Clair, 1998) for the case study organisation. Although unprepared, leadership reacted to the crisis with urgency, it was done in an autocratic manner, and the deployed strategy was perceived by LX as the only option for the organisation to survive. While we cannot speculate that the leadership's decision was incorrect, LX could have tried to influence the employees to "understand and agree about what needs to be done" by facilitating "individual and collective efforts" to address the crisis when it struck, as it might have spared the severity of the measures and enhanced organisational ability to innovate, at the peak of the crisis (Amabile and Pratt, 2016). Evidently, after the leadership had mobilised company resources, the team managed

to adapt to the new normal and tackled the crisis with a variety of innovative solutions in a collaborative manner (Temiz and Broo, 2020).

Although leadership did exhibit one of the "Four I's" of transformational leadership with the low paid employees and P14WS, such as an individualised consideration (Bass and Bass, 2009), the intellectual stimulation, inspirational motivation, idealised influence, or charisma were not reflected in the gathered data. Therefore, employees' emotional needs to deal with the uncertainty, which are considered to be significant (Bluhm et al. 2021), were not addressed fully. That, combined with a lack of communication and clarity, made employees feel insecure, neglected, and unsure about the future. Thus, the trauma of the pandemic was more obvious in those who were left on unpaid leave without any support from the organisation. Looking back at what happened, LX admits that communication flow, information gathering, and sharing could have been better. Furthermore, although not explicitly discussed during the interviews, the establishment of effective remote work practices might have created a better work environment and could have aided the organisational ability to address the COVID-19 crisis more efficiently.

While Company A's crisis response is hardly an example of good practice, paradoxically, the business recovered rather rapidly, without layoffs or post-crisis resignations, and the brand portfolio and client base have substantially increased. However, some of the employees' loyalty to the organisation might have diminished to the point of no return even though their jobs are safe for now. Therefore, to ensure the longevity of the team and to increase the job productivity, crisis or not, the use of the below recommendations coped with some creative teambuilding activities might be beneficial for Company A leadership and its employees going forward.

Recommendation 1: Act with urgency, reassess and adapt continuously

What: research and develop crisis management strategies and put appropriate systems in place. **Why:** to be able to address any future crisis with urgency instead of reacting to it (Kerrissey and Edmondson, 2020). **When:** immediately and reassess annually. **Where:** Company A (HQ) or an external venue. **Who:** LX and management team and possibly external consultant. **How:** perform a brainstorming exercise to review and assess current crisis response using this research and available crisis management models.

Recommendation 2: Promote collaboration

What: step away from autocratic and directive behaviour by promoting bottom-up or middle-out leadership style and shared leadership behaviours (Yukl and Gardner, 2020).

Why: collaborative behaviour promotes creativity and innovation (Helton, 2020). always, but especially when organisational stability is compromised. **Where:** Company A HQ. **Who:** management at all levels. **How:** by way of intrinsic motivation (Amabile and Pratt, 2016) and use of transformational leadership behaviour (Bass and Bass, 2009).

Recommendation 3: Communicate with Transparency

What: employ Mayfield and Mayfield, (2018) MLT. **Why:** to address followers' psychological needs of dealing with uncertainty as it directly correlated with their job performance (Bluhm et al. 2021). **When:** always, but especially when organisational stability is compromised. **Where:** Company A HQ. **Who:** management at all levels. **How:** by adhering to three components of effective communication meaning-making, direction-giving, and empathy.

Recommendation 4: Address remote work practices

What: create a strategy for remote work practices. **Why:** to ensure swift and smooth adaptation if lockdown measures recur. **When:** immediately, as a part of the crisis management system. **Where:** Company A HQ. **Who:** company senior and junior management team. **How:** by using Newman's and Ford's (2021) Five Steps approach and by continuously performing VT Alignment Audit in case of the disbursement of the workforce as a part of standard operating procedures.

5.2 Study Limitations and Future Research

Even though crisis leadership is widely discussed in the academic literature, the topic pertaining to the COVID-19 pandemic is a new and still evolving issue. Therefore, the range of theories for the data analysis was rather limited. Moreover, due to the researcher being an employee of the case study organisation and regardless of the close professional relationships with the participants, possible bias should be considered.

The presented research does not correspond to the population at large, as it is a specific enquiry into the phenomena from only one organisation. Therefore, it might only be relevant to the subjects of this case study. Furthermore, due to the small sample size,

research findings cannot be statistically claimed but can be tested by future research in other organisations using developed themes in the surveys and questionnaires.

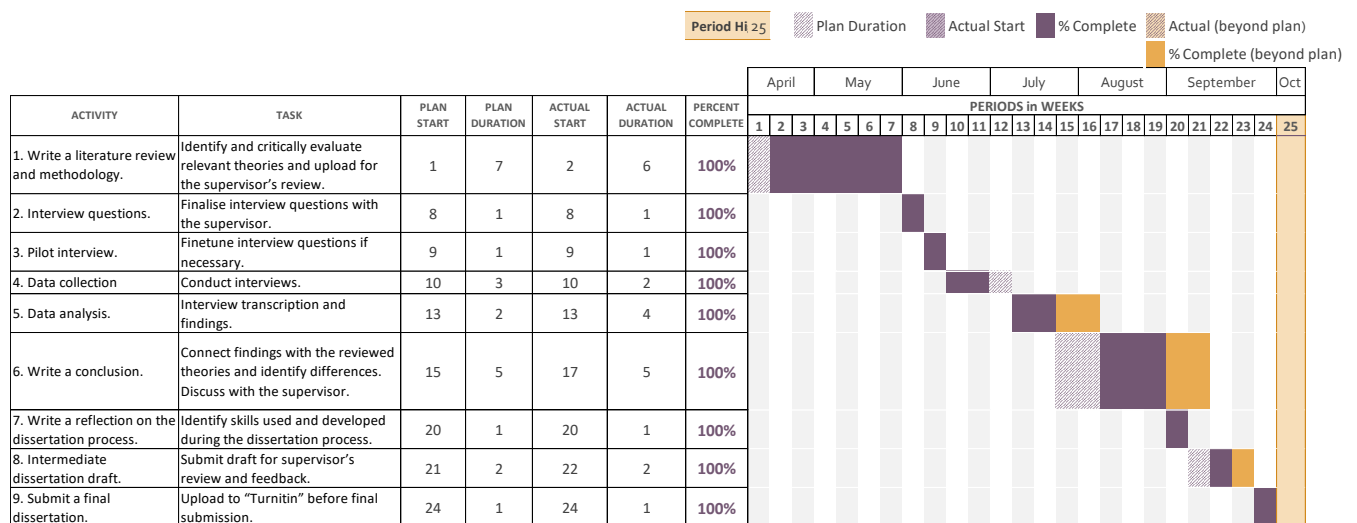
6. Reflection on Dissertation Process

This part presents a researcher's critical reflection on the dissertation process using Gibbs' Reflective Cycle Model (Gibbs 1988 cited in Devet, 2020) as it allows a well-structured self-assessment, by not just describing the process, but also by analysing and reflecting on the experience and learning applied and acquired during the research journey (Devet, 2020).

Description

The aim of this dissertation was to better understand the COVID-19 crisis by using the knowledge gained from relevant literature, my personal experience and the experience of my organisation. The key objectives and milestones set in the beginning of this journey, as indicated in Table 18, were successfully attained, although not always according to the targeted timeline.

Table 18: Dissertation Project Planner – Gantt Chart



Feelings

I was very positive and disciplined in my approach at the beginning of the process, and I felt support from my dissertation supervisor, which was very important to me and a great boost of confidence. The interview process and data transcripts were probably the most challenging parts of the process, especially in the beginning, as it was a new experience. As I progressed to the fifth or sixth interview, I felt more confident and fluent with the follow-up questions. Although, naturally, some of the interviewees were much more talkative and expressive than the others, therefore, the ease of the interview process varied. Another

challenge was to keep some of the interviewees on the topic by trying to pull them back by either repeating the question or rephrasing it so we refocus.

Furthermore, the overall subject of the COVID-19 pandemic is a difficult one, as many of the participants, including myself, went through a traumatic experience of lockdowns and financial instability. Therefore, the interviews were emotionally draining for both myself and the interviewees.

Evaluation

I initially thought that the literature review and the methodology would be the most challenging part of the process, and the qualitative analysis would be easy. Oh, was I wrong! To my surprise, I completed the first two parts without much difficulty as I was very disciplined and focused. I did not expect the interview process, transcript writing and analysis to be so challenging and so time-consuming.

While most of the interviewees were very outspoken, I sometimes hesitated with which follow up questions I should ask. When listening to recordings repeatedly, I realised that, "I should have clarified this or that", "I should have dug deeper here", or, "I should have given a bit more space to answer before I started speaking". I was very critical of myself, but I do think that I improved as I progressed through the interview process. However, I struggled to transcribe broken thoughts and sentences, as they did not sound the same on the paper. It took me longer than expected, and was possibly the least favourite and the most challenging part.

Analysis

As I started this dissertation, the most important thing for me was to stick with the plan and be at my desk during the hours I dedicated explicitly for the study by using Covey's (2016) method of prioritising, the Time Management Matrix. During the first half of the dissertation, I was on top of my tasks, ploughing through literature in an organised manner. I read around the broader subject first and then went deeper into the specific topics, which helped create a structure. I kept a diary and noted phrases from the literature and thoughts that would come into my mind and used them later in the dissertation. I found it very helpful. I was very motivated and wanted to finish ahead of the deadline.

Toward the second half, my motivation dissipated, and I was somewhat reluctant to study. I asked my husband to push me (verbally, of course), and he did, but I did not always listen. I believe the subject of the dissertation and the "dark side" of the research findings might have something to do with it, as this behaviour started to appear right after the completion of the interviews, as evident from the Project Planner (Table 18). While developing transcripts was challenging, I underestimated the psychological and emotional impact that emanated from the interview process, and in addition, I might have felt guilty that I did not pay enough attention to my colleagues during the temporary closure of the business.

Conclusion

The findings from the literature and the case study were intellectually enriching, and I will carry and use this knowledge for the years to come. This is not to say that I have not started using it already. I do pay much more attention to my team members and the way I communicate with them. I exercise transformational leadership behaviours (Bass and Avolio, 1994) in my work and will continue to do so, as I see a great benefit and a positive impact it makes on my team and the business. It is, however, a bit of a challenge to be able to influence LX's leadership behaviours, which sometimes can be difficult, so I just try to shelter my team as much as I can.

The key takeaway from this research was that crisis leadership is not a straightforward matter and that there is no one formula that fits all. However, to me, the human relations, the teamwork, and partnership is the most evident force which can make or break an organisation. As for the research process, I have learned that discipline, focus, and dedication are the most vital attributes. If you have a study plan, stick to it to eliminate the stress and anxiety of approaching deadlines.

Action Plan

As the subject of the COVID-19 crisis is still evolving, and additional literature becomes available, my goal is to explore it further to keep developing my leadership skills. I have also found myself thinking about a PhD level as I have mostly enjoyed this learning journey. It widened my knowledge and capabilities on the personal and the professional level.

For the research process, If I were to do it again, I would set a target to write a minimum number of words a day and write as I read the literature. I would also schedule one interview a day and write a transcript right after the interview has finished, which would definitely save the agony of transcribing all of them simultaneously.

Overall, I could not have been happier with the decision I made to pursue this program, and I look forward to graduation.

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Appendices

Appendix A: HARP Self-Assessment (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2015, pp. 153-156)

4/2/2021

Research methods for business students

Review and discussion questions



Progressing your research project

Heightening your Awareness of your Research Philosophy (HARP)*

HARP is a reflexive tool that has been designed by Bristow and Saunders to help you explore your research philosophy. It is just a starting point for enabling you to ask yourself more refined questions about how you see research. It will not provide you with a definitive answer to the question 'What is my research philosophy?' Rather it will give you an indication as to where your views are similar to and different from those of five major philosophical traditions discussed in this chapter. Do not be surprised

if your views are similar to more than one tradition. Such potential tensions are an ideal opportunity to inquire into and examine your beliefs further.

HARP consists of six sections each comprising five statements (a total of 30 statements). Each section considers one aspect of philosophical beliefs (ontology, epistemology, axiology, purpose of research, meaningfulness of data and structure/agency). Each statement epitomises a particular research philosophy's position in relation to that particular aspect. By indicating your agreement or disagreement with each statement you can discover your similarities and differences with different aspects of each research philosophy. Following the completion of HARP, refer to the scoring key to calculate your score and interpret your answer.

HARP Statements		Strongly Agree	Agree	Slightly Agree	Slightly Disagree	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
Please indicate your agreement or disagreement with the statements below. There are no wrong answers.							
Your views on the nature of reality (ontology)							
1	Organisations are real, just like physical objects.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	Events in organisations are caused by deeper, underlying mechanisms.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	The social world we inhabit is a world of multiple meanings, interpretations and realities.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	'Organisation' is not a solid and static thing but a flux of collective processes and practices.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	'Real' aspects of organisations are those that impact on organisational practices.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
Your views on knowledge and what constitutes acceptable knowledge (epistemology)							
6	Organisational research should provide scientific, objective, accurate and valid explanations of how the organisational world really works.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
7	Theories and concepts never offer completely certain knowledge, but researchers can use rational thought to decide which theories and concepts are better than others.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
8	Concepts and theories are too simplistic to capture the full richness of the world.	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐	☐

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Chapter 4 Understanding research philosophy and approaches to theory development



Progressing your research project (continued)

Heightening your Awareness of your Research Philosophy (HARP)

HARP Statements		Strongly Agree	Agree	Slightly Agree	Slightly Disagree	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
Please indicate your agreement or disagreement with the statements below. There are no wrong answers.							
9	What generally counts as 'real', 'true' and 'valid' is determined by politically dominant points of view.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐
10	Acceptable knowledge is that which enables things to be done successfully.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
Your views on the role of values in research (axiology)							
11	Researchers' values and beliefs must be excluded from the research.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
12	Researchers must try to be as objective and realistic as they can.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
13	Researchers' values and beliefs are key to their interpretations of the social world.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☒
14	Researchers should openly and critically discuss their own values and beliefs.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
15	Research shapes and is shaped by what the researcher believes and doubts.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☒
Your views on the purpose of research							
16	The purpose of research is to discover facts and regularities, and predict future events.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
17	The purpose of organisational research is to offer an explanation of how and why organisations and societies are structured.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
18	The purpose of research is to create new understandings that allow people to see the world in new ways.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
19	The purpose of research is to examine and question the power relations that sustain conventional thinking and practices.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
20	The purpose of research is to solve problems and improve future practice.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
Your views on what constitutes meaningful data							
21	Things that cannot be measured have no meaning for the purposes of research.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐
22	Organisational theories and findings should be evaluated in terms of their explanatory power of the causes of organisational behaviour.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐

Review and discussion questions

HARP Statements		Strongly Agree	Agree	Slightly Agree	Slightly Disagree	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
Please indicate your agreement or disagreement with the statements below. There are no wrong answers.							
23	To be meaningful, research must include participants' own interpretations of their experiences, as well as researchers' interpretations.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
24	Absences and silences in the world around us are at least as important as what is prominent and obvious.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
25	Meaning emerges out of our practical, experimental and critical engagement with the world.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
Your views on the nature of structure and agency							
26	Human behaviour is determined by natural forces.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐
27	People's choices and actions are always limited by the social norms, rules and traditions in which they are located.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
28	Individuals' meaning-making is always specific to their experiences, culture and history.	☐	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐
29	Structure, order and form are human constructions.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☒	☐
30	People can use routines and customs creatively to instigate innovation and change.	☒	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Now please complete the scoring key below.

Your answer scores

Give yourself the points as indicated above for each answer within each philosophical tradition. The different philosophies are represented by specific questions in the HARP as indicated below. Fill each philosophy table with your answer scores, then total up the numbers for each philosophy. (For your reference, in the tables below the letters in brackets indicate whether the question tests your agreement with the ontological, epistemological, axiological, purpose of research, meaningfulness of data and structure and agency aspects of research philosophy.)

Each answer you gave is given a number of points as shown in the table below:

Strongly agree	Agree	Slightly agree	Slightly disagree	Disagree	Strongly disagree
3	2	1	-1	-2	-3

Chapter 4 Understanding research philosophy and approaches to theory development



Progressing your research project (continued)

Heightening your Awareness of your Research Philosophy (HARP)

Positivism: Questions 1, 6, 11, 16, 21, 26

Question	1 (ontology)	6 (epistemology)	11 (axiology)	16 (purpose)	21 (data)	26 (structure/agency)	Total
Answer score	2	2	3	3	-2	-2	6

Critical Realism: Questions 2, 7, 12, 17, 22, 27

Question	2 (ontology)	7 (epistemology)	12 (axiology)	17 (purpose)	22 (data)	27 (structure/agency)	Total
Answer score	2	2	3	3	2	2	14

Interpretivism: Questions 3, 8, 13, 18, 23, 28

Question	3 (ontology)	8 (epistemology)	13 (axiology)	18 (purpose)	23 (data)	28 (structure/agency)	Total
Answer score	3	-1	-3	3	2	2	6

Poststructuralism/postmodernism:

Questions 4, 9, 14, 19, 24, 29

Question	4 (ontology)	9 (epistemology)	14 (axiology)	19 (purpose)	24 (data)	29 (structure/agency)	Total
Answer score	3	-2	3	3	2	-2	7

Pragmatism: Questions 5, 10, 15, 20, 25, 30

Question	5 (ontology)	10 (epistemology)	15 (axiology)	20 (purpose)	25 (data)	30 (structure/agency)	Total
Answer score	2	2	-3	2	2	3	8

Reflection

Now, for the first of what will almost certainly be many philosophical reflections, consider the following questions regarding how you scored yourself.

- 1 Do you have an outright philosophical winner? Or do you have a close contention between two or more philosophies?
- 2 Why do you think this is?
- 3 Which philosophy do you disagree with the most?
- 4 Why do you think this is?

Appendix B: Interview Questions

Question #1 aims at defining the COVID 19 crisis from the perspective of the leader and the followers.

Question to the leader and the followers:

What was the impact of COVID-19 on your organisation? (short-term)

Question #2 is designed to understand the dynamics of the leader-follower relationship.

Question to the leader:

Did you work with team members in a different way during the crisis from how you did before it?

Question to the followers:

Did your line manager work with you in different ways from how they did before the crisis?

Question #3 aims to understand how COVID-19 development was addressed internally, the internal flow of information, and collaboration.

Question to the leader:

Did the way you take decisions change during the crisis?

Question to the followers:

Did the way leadership of the organisation take decisions change during the crisis?

Question #4 is designed to understand priorities of the leader and the followers.

Question to the leader and the followers:

What was important to you at the early stages of the crisis?

Question #5 is designed to understand what went well for the leader and the team in how they managed the crisis?

Question to the leader and the followers:

What went well for you in how you managed the crisis?

Question #6 is designed to understand the organisation's ability to adapt to crisis and overall organisational performance during the crisis.

Question to the leader and the followers:

What do you think the organisation executed well in addressing the crisis?

Appendix C: Participant Information Sheet – Email example (based on Fisher and Buglear, 2010, pp. 76-77)

volha [REDACTED] mail.ru

From: volha [REDACTED] mail.ru
Sent: 09 June 2021 11:37
To: [REDACTED]
Subject: Invitation from Olga Mitra to participate in the MBA research study
Attachments: Research consent form.docx

Dear [REDACTED]

I would like to invite you to take part in my MBA research study. Participation in the project is entirely voluntary. Before you decide, it is important to understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. Please feel free to ask me if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information. Take time to decide whether or not you wish to take part. Thank you for reading this.

What is the purpose of the study?

To find out how the COVID-19 crisis-affected organisation by covering three broad topics: the challenges employees have faced during the crisis, how the organisation reacted to the crisis and thoughts on leadership during crisis.

Why I have been chosen?

You have been chosen because you are communicative and reflective. You have been working in the organisation prior to and during the COVID-19 pandemic, therefore, been directly impacted by the crisis.

Do I have to take part?

It is up to you to decide whether or not to take part. If you do choose to be interviewed, you will be asked to sign the attached consent form or reply to this email by acknowledging and accepting the consent form. If you decide to take part, you are still free to withdraw at any time and without giving a reason.

What will be my involvement if I take part?

The research interview will normally last about 45 minutes to an hour. You will be asked six key questions. You will be asked if you agree to the interview being audio-recorded. If you do not agree to this, the researcher will take written notes during the interview. If you do agree you may still ask for the recorder to be turned off at any point during the interview.

Will my taking part in this study be kept confidential?

Yes. At no point will your identity or identity of your organisation be revealed to anyone other than the academic supervisor and examiner of the project. Your name will not be recorded on any of the research notes that are made and kept as part of the research. All notes, recordings and any other materials will be securely stored. There will be nothing in the material they may have access to that could identify the participants in the study or the organisation they work for.

What will happen to the results of the research study?

The research will be written up as an academic dissertation. It will be stored in the archives at York St. John University.

Who is organising and funding the research?

The research is being undertaken as part of a programme of academic study at York St. John University, leading to the award of an MBA.

Who has reviewed this study?

This study has been reviewed by the Research Ethics Committee of York St. John University.

Looking forward to hearing from you at your earliest convenience,

Appendix D: Research Consent Form - Signed Example



ROBERT KENNEDY COLLEGE
swiss quality education

Est.
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ST JOHN
UNIVERSITY

Research consent form

Dissertation: Crisis Leadership During COVID-19 Pandemic (Case Study)

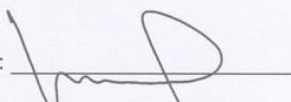
Research conducted by Volha (Olga) Mitra

I have agreed to participate in this research study. I have had the purposes of the research explained to me. I understand that my participation is fully voluntary, and I may withdraw from the process at any time up to two weeks after the interview. Further, I understand that:

My personal identity will be safeguarded. My participation in the research will be regarded as confidential information, and I will not be quoted other than as an anonymous participant in the research.

The findings of the research will be published as a Master's degree dissertation, and may also be published in an academic journal or journals.

I permit the researcher to digitally record the interview, and I am aware the recorded interview will be transcribed for analytical purposes. The data gathered will be solely used for the purposes of the research, will be securely stored and safeguarded, and will be destroyed on completion of the research.

Signature: 

Name: 

Date: 13/06/2021

Appendix E: Partial Interview Transcripts, Codes and Themes

Researcher (R)
Participant (P)

No.	Participant	Salary during the first 3 months of crisis	Reduced Data	Code	Theme
1	P1	No pay	P1: I was surprised that they took decisions without consulting us first as a team. We were just receiving email, out of the blue, one day it was annual leave, a week later unpaid leave. I was bothered by non-communication. Or to ask us, are you ok with it? Is everything fine?	Lack of collaborative behaviour	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
2	P1	No pay	P1: We were just receiving email, out of the blue, one day it was annual leave a week later unpaid leave. I was bothered by non-communication.	Lack of clarity about the situation	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
3	P1	No pay	P1: Or to ask us are you ok with it? Is everything fine?	Non-empathetic approach towards the employees	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
4	P1	No pay	P1: What we were told is, "don't worry we will get to full salary from 2021." We were saying yes to everything, we were also making sacrifice for the company. That is why I thought that they will put us on a full salary from 2021 but it did not happen.	Unrealistic promises to make sure people do not leave	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
5	P1	No pay	P1: our leader did not give me picture of what was happening, I had to find it from my other colleagues in KSA, Kuwait. We all found out by ourselves how we are going to work. Not give you information or any clarity on what was happening. This was frustrating.	Lack of clarity about the situation	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
6	P1	No pay	P1: I did not feel there was support from my CEO. CEO's mind is set, if he does not like the idea, he will cut it off. He thinks he knows what I am thinking. I do not have any choice but to keep quiet. I do not feel respected, I do not feel valued. At times you do not even want to propose things anymore because you do not feel valued. But you still do it anyway.	The leader has no interest in what employee has to say	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
7	P1	No pay	P1: Will I keep my job to have a salary? To understand, am I going to keep my job, can I trust them? I was afraid that after 3 months they will tell that we have to let you go. They did not explain why they took this decision. I was freaking out the entire pandemic. I was telling them that I was worried. I asked them to give me a little money to reimburse later and it was denied.	No assurance of stability	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
8	P1	No pay	They did not explain why they took this decision. I was freaking out the entire pandemic.	Lack of communications with the employees	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
9	P1	No pay	I was telling them that I was worried.	Non-empathetic approach towards the employees	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
10	P1	No pay	I asked them to give me a little money to reimburse later and it was denied.	Insensitivity toward employees basic survival needs	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
11	P1	No pay	P1: There was not much to do, so we were trying to find new ideas.	Initiative to innovate	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
12	P1	No pay	P1: Our leadership just told us to try to find ideas. He did not sit with us, we brainstormed ourselves. We came with an idea, this is the cost and he liked the idea and he approved it and it was done.	Initiative to innovate with minimum guidance	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
13	P1	No pay	My focus was to understand what happened to my brands during this time, with retailers. To understand what was the status of the brands. What kind of restrictions we had with the retailers? This was tough.	Initiative with the minimum guidance	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
14	P1	No pay	P1: I kept my job. Even though I do not agree with the management style but at the end of the day we kept our jobs. I learned that it was possible to work from home as I thought it was not possible. I used to wait for weekly meeting with the leader. If he is on teams, he just says what he has to say and then bye. He does not have time; he is very busy. It happened several times when I wanted to share an idea, he said he does not have time and I should discuss it with country managers.	Initiative to innovate with minimum guidance	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
15	P1	No pay	P1: Primary thing is we are happy we kept our jobs.	Important	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
16	P1	No pay	P1: I felt safe because they started imposing social distancing and gave us choice to work from home. There is always a hand sanitiser and pile of	Important	Effective personal safety measures reduce worry during the pandemic.
17	P1	No pay	P1: As a CEO of this size of company there is a room for communication. You need to say it face to face to make us understand, that if you want to talk my door is open. People still have rents to pay, electricity, food, those kinds of expenses will not change. It is only the communication. But I understand that we need to sacrifice a bit. Not enough communication as everybody was scared. They could have been more familiar with us. I honestly thought, when I got another letter for 50% salary, I did not feel safe anymore.	Non-empathetic approach towards the employees. Pure communication.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
18	P1	No pay	P1: The main point is communication. Even without communication he managed to keep the company, that is a bit funny!	Paradox	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
19	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: The direct consequence was the loss of turnover. This is more impactful with no visibility because we did not know how it's going.	Revenue loss. No clarity of the future.	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
20	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: First of March I thought it is like a flu. But I think nobody anticipated it in the beginning.	No preparation prior to pandemic.	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
21	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: It was damage control. Turnover will not come, finish. So what can we do? Are we ready for something else? No! So, limit the consequences on the company because the company had to run one day. We took a decision to stop for three months, you know, not paying salaries for three months.	No preparation prior to pandemic. Radical measures to stop company operation indefinitely.	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
22	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: I talked to a lot of people from the big companies. How to? They do not know. Everybody was the same. What we are doing is damage control, damage control, damage control.	Looking at how other companies behave without consulting the internal	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
23	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: Most impactful on me was "What I would do in June if it remains the same."	Frustration about unknown	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
24	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: What was most important for me was that I felt that in my organisation, my employees were supportive.	Support from the employees.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
25	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: We had a monthly letter sent to them. Maybe, this thing (communication), we should do better, to talk more.	Lack of communications with the employees	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
26	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: We favoured people with a small salary	Employees were supported selectively.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.

27	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: Maybe we could have some brainstorming, get more ideas at earlier stages.	Lack of collaborative behaviour to promote innovation at the early stages of pandemic.	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
28	P2 Leader X	Leader X	R: Was there the same level of collaboration? P2: It was not.	Lack of collaborative behaviour	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
29	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: It was not. There was no business, no decisions to take! We had to follow the flow.	Lack of action from the leadership	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
30	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: Damage control was based on the cash we had. This kind of decision, I am the only one who can take it.	Autocratic behaviour	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
31	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: When it opened here (UAE), we start making lots of sales via WhatsApp.	Innovation at the late stages of crisis	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
32	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: The cost was nothing. There was no risk.	Innovate at no cost only	Survival of the business as a top priority.
33	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: The idea started in Kuwait. It was not a strategic decision.	Staff initiative to innovate	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
34	P2 Leader X	Leader X	R: What was important to you? P2: It is to maintain the business after the crisis and to maintain my team.	retrench during the crisis with the hope to come back	Survival of the business as a top priority.
35	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: I had two choices, either I keep everybody without salary for three months, or I start to get rid of people.	Leadership acted with urgency to preserve financial capital in order to ensure continuity.	Survival of the business as a top priority.
36	P2 Leader X	Leader X	R: When you made this critical decision for the organisation to survive, did you convey or explain your plans to the team? P2: Maybe I did not explain enough (to the employees). I was not clear in my head because nobody knew, nobody was expecting that.	Leader's X acknowledgement of the lack of communication and transparency due to an	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
37	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: It was the best time to acquire good brands as a lot of companies were struggling. I knew this pandemic would not last forever.	Looking for opportunities to expand the brand portfolio.	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
38	P2 Leader X	Leader X	We do not have to panic. There is a hard decision to be taken but no panic.	The key priority is to safeguard the capital and retrench until it blows over.	Survival of the business as a top priority.
39	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: For example, I did not go on holiday. I could go, but I did not. I will not go on holiday when my employees are without salaries. I want them to understand that we are all in the same boat.	Personal sacrifice to demonstrate awareness of the staff's financial	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
40	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: I know it was hard for my employees. But by the end of the day, I reach my goal to maintain the business.	The key priority is to safeguard the capital and resume after the crisis.	Survival of the business as a top priority.
41	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: I will not do anything differently if it happens again, maybe if I had more cash—this kind of decision you can't plan.	No recognition of crisis planning strategy	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
42	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: We talked to the suppliers to extend our credit terms. Suppliers were very supportive of that.	A key priority is to safeguard the capital	Survival of the business as a top priority.
43	P2 Leader X	Leader X	It was a very interesting situation. It shows our ability to control the damage. It is 25 years of experience, but what we learned is that nothing will be maintained forever, and also to be prepared.	A key priority is to safeguard the capital	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
44	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: Talk to our suppliers to delay payment. Manage not to get expenses in the company. My only concern was how to keep the cash in the company to pay for few months.	A key priority is to safeguard the capital and resume after the crisis.	Survival of the business as a top priority.
45	P2 Leader X	Leader X	P2: Maybe we did not say it, but everybody understood that we are in this together.	Very little understanding of the staffs' struggles	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
46	P3	No pay	P3: It was very sudden; we were not prepared to close immediately. Everything stopped suddenly, we received an email that company is on the lock down.	The crisis was not anticipated by the leadership. No one was	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
47	P3	No pay	I was not prepared to stop. I was receiving calls from suppliers asking me questions. I did not know what to answer to the suppliers. They were surprised that we completely closed the offices.	Lack of collaborative behaviour in the decision making to stop the business for three months	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
48	P3	No pay	P3: Absolutely disappointed, frustrated and anxious. I was afraid. what will happen. It was an anxiety if we reopen, when?	An employee at the state of panic and frustration	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
49	P3	No pay	R: Did you have any clarity on what is going to happen, from your leadership? P3: It was not clear.	Poor communication	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
50	P3	No pay	R: What was the reaction from the suppliers? They were asking why we are not working from home as nobody stopped the operation. Everybody was doing training online.	Poor communication with suppliers	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
51	P3	No pay	R: They (suppliers) were not informed from the HQ? P3: No! They were not informed. Only after a while.	Poor communication with suppliers	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
52	P3	No pay	R: Were you consulted on the decision to close? P3: No!	Automatic behaviour. Lack of collaboration with the team.	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
53	P3	No pay	R: So, there was no collaboration? P3: We had a team meeting when they were explaining themselves why this is happening. But it was lacking the business long-term though. Without thinking, that we still can work from home at list one or twice a week.	A directive approach without taking into account staff's suggestions to explore online opportunities	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
54	P3	No pay	P3: Yes! The answer was "I clearly told you direct everything to office assistant".	A directive approach without taking into account staff's suggestions to explore online opportunities	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
55	P3	No pay	We were doing masterclasses online, social media, advises and training - Approaching end consumers directly. We have not done this before.	New ways of doing things	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
56	P3	No pay	This came from senior management. They said that we need to start selling. All the team was exchanging ideas without senior management.	Directive approach	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.

57	P3	No pay	R: What was important to you at the early stages of the crisis? P3: Personally, that I am not made redundant. That I still have my job. Professional, it did not happen in the beginning: to continue communications with suppliers but it did not happen because I was not paid.	Important to secure the job and remain professional with the clients	Job security is of the highest priority for the employees during the crisis.
58	P3	No pay	R: Have you conveyed it to your leader? P3: Yes. But I was turned down, clearly, so I did not approach anymore.		Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
59	P3	No pay	P3: The whole world went online, and we did not have that. We were a little bit late. At that time, I proposed to senior management to create an app for trading, with quotations. We could have had a beautiful web shop and it was turned down as money were involved.	No resources allocation to develop online activities at the early stages of the pandemic. Missed opportunity.	Survival of the business as a top priority.
60	P3	No pay	R: How did it make you feel when you received the rejection on your proposal? P3: I felt very bad! My ideas are not valid, and decisions are like "one men show". We just following what we are instructed to do. Most of our proposals were turned down and I feel bad. It was very detailed plan. It was turned down without reason stated.	Autocratic, dismissive behaviour from the leadership. No appreciation for the staff's initiative to innovate.	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
61	P3	No pay	R: Have you felt that your proposal was appreciated? P3: No. He just said, "I saw it", that's it.	No appreciation for the staff's initiative to innovate. Demotivated team.	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
62	P3	No pay	P3: No, it was not clear, they were always saying, "maybe next month" and then "maybe next month". Only from new year we were absolutely clear about how we will come back to the full salary.	Unclear communication from the leadership	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
63	P3	No pay	P3: During our meeting we were asking to clarify. Before that it was very unclear.	Employees had to confront the leadership to clarify the situation going forward.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
64	P3	No pay	P3: No, nothing was well! From the beginning we were unclear, anxious, panicking. Why were we closing so suddenly?	Staff felt insecure and unstable due to poor communication on what was happening and what is going to happen	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
65	P3	No pay	P3: If company did not close down, we could have started earlier.	Missed opportunity and state of panic upon	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
66	P3	No pay	R: Do you feel certain about the future? P3: Yes. But we lost these 3 months. It could have been very good preparation to kick off. We were panicking how to start, where to start?	Missed opportunity and state of panic upon reopening	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
67	P3	No pay	P3: Lost business. Lost touch with the accounts, lost opportunities to educate the clients. Lost opportunities to reach new audience, to implement e-com to have direct sales. Just lost opportunities. That is it.	Missed opportunities to innovate and adjust during the crisis	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
68	P4	No pay	P4: There is no footfall during the lockdowns. If no customers are going to the mall, they have to close the company as well. They were kept saying that if they did not put us on unpaid leave, the company would go bankrupt.	Temporary closure of the business is seen as the only option to safeguard the company	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
69	P4	No pay	P4: I thought it was harsh. It was very inhumane. You have been forced to take your leave without any salary at all, no food allowance, but we still need to pay our bills.	No empathy for the staff's struggles, but they are still grateful that no one is terminated.	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
70	P4	No pay	P4: I was trying to find out why not just limit the number of employees for the business to keep going.	There were still business opportunities out there. Unrealised opportunities	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
71	P4	No pay	P4: When I received the email about the unpaid leave, I replied by asking, "Why?".	Impersonal communication announcing business closure for three months	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
72	P4	No pay	R: Did your line manager work with you in a different way from how they did before the crisis? P4: There is a big difference. He is somehow stricter in terms of budget, expenses, how he deals with people.	Tightening financial control	The new normal presents tighter financial control. (Capital is priority)
73	P4	No pay	P4: Working digitally, you can still get things done, but it is more difficult to coordinate vs being in the office.	Remote work does not have the same ease of communication	Remote teamwork does not have the same ease of communication.
74	P4	No pay	P4: Decision making changed during the crisis. It changed a lot. Each expense is recorded by the accounts, and each expense needs his (Leader X) signature.	Tightening financial control	The new normal presents tighter financial control. (Capital is priority) (Autocratic)
75	P4	No pay	P4: He (Leader X) took over the control in each project.	Command and control	The new normal presents tighter financial control. (Capital is priority) (Autocratic)
76	P4	No pay	P4: Cut expenses like production costs by reusing the materials.	Tightening financial control	The new normal presents tighter financial control. (Capital is priority)
77	P4	No pay	P4: We are always brainstorming with a team. The manager told us to cut your cost, "this is too much", so the team finds a way how to.	Directive leadership, tightening financial control	The new normal presents tighter financial control. (Capital is priority) (Collaborative)
78	P4	No pay	R: What was important to you? P4: Family, that everyone is safe and my job.	Important (priority)	Job security is of the highest priority for the employees during the crisis.
79	P4	No pay	P4: I also panicked. Financially I was not fully stable. When it comes to security on a personal basis, it worried me. How long will this company not pay me?	No sense of stability, unclear future	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
80	P4	No pay	R: How much update did you have during these two months? P4: We only received two emails	Poor communication with the staff during the early stages of crisis	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
81	P4	No pay	R: Did you convey your financial difficulties to your leadership? P4: Yes, it is also hard on him (leader X), and he has a full team to think about. All of us need to undergo this. They did not give any support. It saddened me. It is sad. I did not expect this from the management. It was a bit harsh, inhumane. It's one-way traffic. He just save his company, but he did not think of his employee's welfare at the time. At least he should give some allowance for food like other companies were doing. At least 20% of the salary to survive.	No empathy toward some of the staff, even when asked for personal financial help for basic needs	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
82	P4	No pay	R: What went well for you in how you managed this crisis? P4: I had to study social media. That's the best side of it. When I joined, they said we need to go digital.	New learning, acquiring new skills	Innovation promotes new learning and vice versa.
83	P4	No pay	R: What do you think the organisation executed well during the crisis? P4: Well... when they asked everyone to go back to work. That's the best decision they have ever made. ha hah.	Although the staff is upset with the unpaid leave, they are grateful they still have their jobs	Job security is of the highest priority for the employees during the crisis.
84	P4	No pay	R: Would you do anything differently? No. No. It is only that point that they could have given at least 20-30% of the salary. In the long term, he saved everyone's job. We don't need to look for another job.	Desire to have basic support for the staff during difficult times	Job security is of the highest priority for the employees during the crisis.

85	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	R: What was the impact of COVID-19 on your organisation? P5: When the rumours started, we were still working on our projects. We don't know what's happening, what we will do. Management said that everything is under control, we have planned for this.	Projection of calm by the leadership	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
86	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: We did not stop. We were meeting every week, talking about what is happening. I was keeping management updated on what I was doing. I was always in touch with the management.	Communications did not break during the crisis in Qatar as staff continued working and engaged	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
87	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: For me, it was new that Leader X started to be involved in everything. Before it was not like that. We were meeting every week (online).	More control from the leadership	The new normal presents tighter control.
88	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: It was very clear. The blurriness was only for one month when everybody did not know what's happening.	No clarity during the early stages of crisis	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
89	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: Personally, it was important to keep my job, at least part of my salary. This was very important for me. We are all expats. Most important, we can secure ourselves. It was important to know how I can survive; we have rent and bills.	Important	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
90	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: I think we managed it all together and individually. We adapted ourselves. Cooperation from both sides was very good.	Good level of cooperation	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
91	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: Extra payment terms. Free goods, gifts to consumers. Its cooperation from both sides.	Allocation of additional resources to support the business	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
92	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: Yes, before the pandemic, we were going to have a physical event with Brand owners. So, we said it would be nice, if we are not able to do it, we send a personal message to all the attendees from the Brand and also gifts. I discussed this idea with Leader X [...] he agreed; he said ok it is a good idea. It had a positive impact, and people started talking about our products and asking about it. We did an online Instagram event.	Successful, innovative ideas from the staff	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
93	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	R: Did you have a chance to hear what other area managers are doing for a different brand? P5: Actually, not much. We had only one meeting with the countries, with a team. Maybe two times.	Poor information flow between the countries	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
94	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: Flexibility, they were very flexible in supporting ideas or giving support in my country, at least.	Allocation of additional resources to support the business	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
95	P5	50% salary, enforced by the Qatari government	P5: Whatever was available at that time, we did it, I think. I think we did it in a proper way.	Successful handling of the pandemic in Qatar	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
96	P6	No pay	P6: In the beginning, there was no organised plan for what we will do. Everything was messed up. After one month, we started thinking about what the option to run the business is. So the impact was honestly.... In the first two months, it was a disaster: cutting costs, cutting salaries.	Late pandemic response. Organisation was not prepared.	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
97	P6	No pay	P6: Before the lockdown, did you feel a threat? No, we thought it is going to pass by. Maybe it is Arab mentality. We did not have plans, nothing at all.	The organisation was not prepared, the pandemic was not anticipated.	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
98	P6	No pay	P6: Frustrated. Depression. We don't know what is going to happen in the future. It was crazy. You cant see the end of the tunnel.	Panic amongst the staff: no clarity, organisational support or direction.	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic.
99	P6	No pay	P6: We create something. R: What do you mean by We? P6: I started with myself: making ideas.	Staff initiative to innovate to generate the business	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
100	P6	No pay	R: So if you would describe the impact on the organisation with few words? The short term impact. P6: Lost. Everybody was lost.	Panic amongst the staff: no clarity, organisational support or direction.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
101	P6	No pay	P6: Of course. All the line managers started listening to you. "If you have any ideas, share them with us".	Communications improved after the second month. Staff initiative to innovate to generate the business	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
102	P6	No pay	R: What was important to you at the early stages of the crisis? P6: To feel safe, finance wise. The most threatening thing was stability.	Important	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
103	P6	No pay	R: What did you do to achieve that (stability)? P6: I tried to think outside of the box. To get some money and to show the company that I am doing something.	Staff initiative to innovate to generate the business	Innovation promotes new learning and vice versa.
104	P6	No pay	P6: Most of the action I took was very successful, and the company was supportive. Again, this is after two months of struggling.	Leadership start providing support for the new ideas after the second month of the pandemic.	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.

105	P6	No pay	R: Where you briefed about the strategy for the company, did you have clarity? P6: Yes, yes. There was a daily briefing.	Communications improved after the second month of pandemic	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
106	P6	No pay	R: Did they implement a similar strategy in the other markets? P6: I have no idea. I have no clue.	No centralised information sharing between the countries	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
107	P6	No pay	R: What do you think the organisation executed well in addressing this crisis? P6: Nothing, nothing. They were just cutting costs, nothing else.	Retrench during the crisis with the hope to come back. Protect company	Survival of the business as a top priority.
108	P6	No pay	P6: They (company leadership) should have a few months of salaries for the employees. But not in one day just say "from tomorrow you don't have a salary".	Feeling of abandonment by the company	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
109	P6	No pay	R: How did you receive this news? P6: In a bad way, very bad way. I did not feel safe at all. I felt unsafe for the first couple of months.	Feeling unsafe and unstable	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
110	P6	No pay	R: Did you receive updates on what was happening? P6: Unfortunately, no.	No clarity during the early stages of crisis	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
111	P6	No pay	P6: It was a learning curve for me. Start saving money. They don't give a damn if you are not getting your salary.	Staff does not feel valued or appreciated. Feel abandoned	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
112	P8	No pay	P8: Online business took leadership. Online could be a massive stream of income. In case something similar happens in the future, you would not be that affected.	Realising the business potential in online (e-commerce), away from traditional retail	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
113	P8	No pay	P8: The reason it got stuck as they need to invest.	No resources allocation to develop online activities at the early stages of the pandemic. Missed opportunity.	Survival of the business as a top priority.
114	P8	No pay	P8: More meetings to set up a new way to approach the business. All info I brought from the market, we discussed immediately.	The team started to be more active after three months. Better information flow. Quick response to the enquiries.	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
115	P8	No pay	P8: It was clear and not clear. They just take advantage of the situation. They can save more and make more profit by paying us less.	Staff remained uncertain when they resumed back at 50% salary.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
116	P8	No pay	P8: Changes in the different decisions on how to run the business. Double and triple check (more control). The ordering process was delayed and reduced quantity, which impacted the business.	More control from the leadership	The new normal presents tighter financial control.
117	P8	No pay	P8: To get back to work.	Important	Job security is of the highest priority for the employees during the crisis.
118	P8	No pay	P8: During unpaid leave, there were no activities whatsoever. It was just me trying to come up with the solution to come back to work early. That's where I came up with the online.	Staff initiative to innovate to generate the business	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
119	P8	No pay	P8: No, I was motivating myself to get the salaries back. I was trying to share my ideas at the office.	Staff initiative to innovate to generate the business without leadership's motivation.	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
120	P8	No pay	R: Would you do anything differently? P8: I would keep all the employees at least on 20% salary and not the unpaid leave, especially if you have a cash flow. To take care of the people who produce 80% of your revenue.	Feeling of abandonment by the company	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
121	P8	No pay	P8: Taking care of the people will produce more. I would sit down with everyone and ask: How much are your expenses? How much do you pay for your car loan, for your electricity?. At least you cover basic expenses and food. That would mean a lot for your employees. People will not leave the organisation because of the money people leave when they don't feel appreciated.	Lack of empathetic behaviour from the leadership. Staff feeling unappreciated.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
122	P8	No pay	R: Was it easy to communicate online with your team, with the leader? P8: For the business meetings, it was ok. For sales training, I found it difficult as productivity is not the same. You can control the crowd better in person. Online, it was just like a brick wall between you and the person.	Remote work does not have the same ease of communication.	Remote teamwork does not have the same ease of communication.
123	P11	No pay	P11: I felt very uneasy. I had no clue what was going on. I was not prepared for the zoom call we had (announcement about three months unpaid leave). It was the most shocking call.	No prior communications about the crisis. Autocratic behaviour. Team was not consulted about the drastic measures leadership was taking.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
124	P11	No pay	P11: I think I cried every day for about a month. I went into a bit of shock, and I felt very alone.	Emotional distress and feeling alone	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
125	P11	No pay	P11: The company just left us for three months and longer, without pay, knowing that we don't live here, not knowing our financial situations. I did feel a bit angry and a bit hurt that it was an inappropriate thing to do to people who worked for them (company leadership).	Feeling of abandonment by the organisation. No empathy of concern for the employee's wellbeing	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
126	P11	No pay	P11: It is obvious that no one knew how to handle this situation, but I think that in the world that we are living today, technology is so freeing. There is so much we could do. I feel that there should have been a strategy meeting. We could have created a youtube channel with all these different content things that we could have done during the lockdown.	Surprised by the company inaction to pivot the business toward online. No collaboration with the team members to hear what they have to say or offer.	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
127	P11	No pay	They don't care about you. You are just a number. They want to save the company, but I am just a number, so why would I try anything.	Employee does not want to help the company anymore as they don't feel valued or important. People do not matter	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
128	P11	No pay	After that meeting, I never heard anything from him (Leader X) for like six weeks. Everything just completely stopped, no communication.	No communication from the leadership, no updates, no enquiries about the employees wellbeing	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
129	P11	No pay	R: When you returned, how was the interaction with your leader? P11: Everything was the same. I was a bit different. It took me a while to be able to want to go back to the office. I was a lot quieter than before.	Demotivated employee. Uneasy about going back to work.	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.

130	P11	No pay	P11: We were told what we had to do. We did get asked to come in and discuss what we can do online.		Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
131	P11	No pay	P11: The brands were asking where everybody was. They thought we all got fired as there was no communication. Once brands started questioning leader X he asks us about what we can do online.	No communication with suppliers. Leadership started to act only after suppliers started	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
132	P11	No pay	R: What was important to you at the early stages of crisis? P11: How do I pay my rent? How can training continue? To try to keep my team. I wanted to make sure I kept the team and that everybody could work and function	Important	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
133	P11	No pay	R: What do you mean when you said, "I had no idea what was going on"? P11: Well, I obviously don't know the company's financial situation, so when your Leader X tells you that they will stop paying you, it does make you think. Will this company survive? Is the company in trouble? Am I going to get to the end of three months of unpaid leave, and they decide to close the	No clarity about the future. No comunication from the leadership on what to expect. No sence of stability.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
134	P11	No pay	P11: My point is if I was valued, I would not be in this position when I have to ask. He (Leader X) obviously does not think that way.	Feeling devalued, demotivated. No empathy from the leadership.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
135	P11	No pay	P11: I never thought about leaving the company before, even I have been offered more money. If the UK was open, I would have probably gone home by now.	No more loyalty for the organisation	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
136	P11	No pay	P11: I felt the company did not value you as a person. They did not check to see and ask how is the situation.	Feeling devalued, demotivated. No empathy from the leadership.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
137	P11	No pay	R: What went well for you in how you managed this crisis? P11: I was able to adapt to online and Instagram. I think I learned I could adapt to the situation (doing new things online).	New learning, acquiring new skills	Innovation promotes new learning and vice versa.
138	P11	No pay	R: Is it easy for you to recall these events? P11: No, I feel I am going to cry now. It was one of the hardest things I had to do as I am alone here. There is no one to give you a hug and tell you; you are ok.	High level of emotional distress about what happened and how the organisation addressed this crisis by not doing enough for their employees	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.
139	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	R: Did you have clarity about how the organisation was going to handle it? P12: When the pandemic hit on the market, we really did not know. We made a plan for one year, 50% salary then slowly slowly to 70%. We coped with the situation.	Organisation was unprepared, Crisis came unexpectedly.	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
140	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	P12: It was all management who decided. We know that we will not have a business for one year, so they decided, ok, let's reduce the salaries. At least they can give 50% of the salary to every staff.	Leadership anticipated no business for one year. Selective, low-cost employees were kept on 50% salary.	Survival of the business as a top priority.
141	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	All the decisions are taken by our CEO. You know, actually, there are many things which are always a secret between the CEO and others who worked on this plan.	Autocratic leadership	Autocratic decision-making during crisis limits opportunities to address it more effectively.
142	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	P12: Well, I am not fully aware of what was a plan, but yes, there was a plan for one year.	Staff knows there is a plan but does not know what it	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
143	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	P12: It is not a plan. We signed that we would get 50% salary for one year, but we will keep our jobs. R: So you had clarity? P12: Yes.	Low-paid employees were aware of the the one year cost-cutting plan	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
144	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	P12: My line manager was in the same way as before. Very helpful. We were so close, more interactive and more communicative with each other on WhatsApp on teams. We were so active at that time.	Close communication between the team members who were still	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
145	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	R: What was important to you at the early stages of the crisis? P12: Do everything on time, as per schedule, as we cannot lose our clients. We were mainly concerned about the company business. We were very very scared.	Important	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
146	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	R: And on the personal level? P12: How we goanna survive. So financial stability, pay for school, for fees, loans.	Important	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
147	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	R: Did you feel secure at the time? P12: I was not secure because we don't know how long it is going to be in our lives. At that time, it was important for me to have a job.	Uncertainty about the future.	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
148	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	R: Did you start doing some things in a new way during the pandemic? P12: Yes, we started receiving orders on WhatsApp. Management decided, let's create a WhatsApp for ordering. R: When did this happen? Can you recall? P12: The second month. The first month we really did not know what's going to happen, how long this will take. The shops were closed for three months.	Leadership started taking actions and doing things differently into the second month of the pandemic.	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
149	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	R: What do you think the organisation executed well? I think the organisation did a very good thing. They did not fire anyone.	Employee is greatfull that she still had a job.	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
150	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	P12: We had clear information that we will get our full salaries after one year. We were clearly informed that we would get it after one year after business reopened.	Low-paid employees were aware of the the one year cost-cutting plan vs no salary and cuts for the rest of the organisation.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
151	P12	50% (lower-cost employee)	R: Would you do anything differently? P12: Working from home was a new thing. We never worked from home. It was not a bad experience. But when we work in the office environment, it's good. But communicate from home is not easy with the ERP system.	Challenges working from home	Remote teamwork does not have the same ease of communication.
152	P14	No pay	P14: It was a completely shocking change. No advance information. It just happened.	The crisis came unexpectedly. The organisation was not	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
153	P14	No pay	P14: First three months, we did not have any compensation. It was very scary for us. It was very difficult. It was very stressful. Somehow, we did something after three months. It was a surviving scenario like I was living in the movie. My mind got frizzed, what to do. I was just thinking about how to survive.	The employee was in emotional distress due to a lack of support or clarity about the future from Organisation A at the early stages of the pandemic.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
154	P14	No pay	R: How did it make you feel? P14: It gave me a very bad feeling. It is like you reach the point that you are completely powerless. All I could do is hope and pray. There was no expectations, nothing.	The employee was in emotional distress due to a lack of support or clarity about the future from Organisation A at the early stages of the pandemic.	The absence of leadership's support during difficult times promotes panic and resentment.

155	P14	No pay	R: What was important to you at the early stages of the crisis? P14: The important thing to me is to provide necessary and basic things to my family.	Important (Priority)	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
156	P14	No pay	R: Did you ask for it (financial support)? The first few months, they were given vacation days salary, but after I pursued them with a personal request for finances, they supported me.	Company A provided financial support to the struggling employee upon request.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
157	P14	No pay	R: During this time, what was your team focused on? P14: Organisation gave us nothing at that time, so it was very difficult to face my team (retail team) to answer to them. We were panicking if we are going to continue or not.	No clear communication about the situation from the leadership. No sense of stability about the future.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
158	P14	No pay	R: What went well for you in how you managed this crisis? P14: We maintained our jobs. We (are) still working to date. I am very thankful and grateful that I have managed to survive with my family, providing accommodation, food, medical help to my mom.	The employee is grateful to have a job at the end of the pandemic.	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
159	P14	No pay	R: What do you think the organisation executed well in addressing this crisis? P14: Well, they have played it in a very professional way. They were trying to show honesty. They were offering support. They were trying to retain people. It is an outstanding execution to maintain employment. And they maintained all the brands.	Despite the lack of communication and transparency employee is grateful that company A retained their staff and the business post pick of the crisis	Job security is of the highest priority for th employees during the crisis.
160	P14	No pay	R: When you said offering support, how would you define that? P14: I, personally, have received support verbally a couple of times. When I personally requested support, they did not reject it. Our CEO was aware of my personal life, one day he called me and said, look Safi, I am going to do whatever I can do so you can manage to pay for electricity (etc.). It makes me feel that they are trying their level best. When I asked that I had financial difficulties, he asked why I did not come earlier and asked me.	Company leadership was empathetic to the employee and provided financial support to the struggling employee upon request.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
161	P14	No pay	R: Would you do anything differently in the way the crisis was addressed? P14: Personally, I tried anything to make money. R: An alternative income? P14: Yes, yes. I tried to do side business. For the company, also alternative revenue. During the pandemic, it would not work. There is no chance for us to think about any revenue.	The employee did not see alternative revenue options for the company during the pandemic.	Not being prepared for the crisis reduces chances for appropriate response.
162	P14	No pay	P14: During the third month, we start applying/facilitating online. Form the company it was completely new.	The organisation started to innovate at the later stages of a pandemic.	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
163	P14	No pay	R: Was it easy? P14: When you are face to face meeting, it works in a better way, but it was the best tool in hand for us to use.	Remote work does not have the same ease of communication.	Remote teamwork does not have the same ease of communication.
164	P9	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P9: I felt they handled it well. They started implementing things quickly. It was a 30% (salaries) cut for the employees. They were able to keep running. I don't think, globally, anyone was fired.	Organisation B acted with urgency and kept employees engaged.	Being prepared for the crisis increases chances for appropriate response.
165	P9	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P9: Everything went very smoothly. We were able to adapt very quickly, online and everything.	Organisation B acted with urgency, shifted online and kept employees engaged.	Being prepared for the crisis increases chances for appropriate response.
166	P9	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P9: With Company B we had to be present on camera from 9 to 5. They made us watch training all day. I come from the sale background I don't operate like that, always on my computer. I did not think I could last long like that	Challenges working from home	Online fatigue
167	P9	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P9: You know, financially, I was not hit.	Felt financially secured.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
168	P9	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P9: Did it have an effect, this approach? Honestly, Yes. Yes, our clients were very happy because they wanted to occupy their staff. It took time, a few months to finish. So you were busy? Yes, it was crazy for me. I was working during the nights creating presentations from scratch.	Productive period by implementing new ways to be engaged with the clients which had a long term positive impact	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
169	P9	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P9: Online schooling for my daughter... It was crazy. It was very stressful. This is something I did not handle well. R: Have you addressed this matter to your manager? P9: Yes, they were ok with it.	Stressful period with homeschooling the kids, but Organisation B was flexible and understanding.	Good work-life boundaries supported by the organisation.

170	P9	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P9: What do you think your organisation executed well in addressing this crisis? They were able to retain people, to keep them motivated. They made sure we switched jobs. They were well able to work this out and do not leave people behind.	Employees were supported by Organisation B and stayed motivated.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
171	P10	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P10: It was very proactive. We were immediately in touch with HQ. It was really the best moment in this difficult situation. We were always in touch on a daily basis with HQ. Psychologically it helped a lot. (Company B)	Quick action from Organisation B. Full clarity of what is going to happen. Clear communication of what to expect. The employee felt secure and supported, engaged and proactive.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
172	P10	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	One of the company owners called me asking me how you are. It was very important for me. I felt safe. I was really taken care of emotionally.	Empathetic behaviour from Company B's leadership	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.
173	P10	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P10: It was really such a protective moment in such a difficult time. In the first week itself, we were already informed what is going to happen. We had clarity.	The employee had full clarity and stability	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
174	P10	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	R: What impact did it have? P10: Until now, some of the accounts kept the recordings of the webinars we had during the lockdown. A lot of educational content. The client appreciated this effort.	Productive period by implementing new ways to be engaged with the clients which had a long term positive impact	Innovating is the way to sustain the business.
175	P10	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	R: What went well for you in how you managed the crisis? P10: Personally, I was able to manage to anticipate my financial situation.	The employee felt financially stable due to the transparent leadership behaviour and clear communication.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
176	P10	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	R: What kind of learning? How to anticipate when the demand comes back. We were attending seminars with the French business consul(tant), given tips and trend analysis when the economy is back. Also, with the UK, we were given an analysis of how the clients will react when the business comes back. The analysis we were given anticipated a quick economic comeback, and it materialised.	Organisation B made sure to educate their staff about the impact of the crisis and what to expect post-crisis: how to handle the business best.	Information sharing and collaborative behaviour amongst team members and clients help to advance the business.
177	P10	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	R: What do you think the organisation (B) executed well in addressing this crisis? The fast reaction or fast response to the situation. This is the first thing I can always remember, how they tackled the situation immediately, given us assurance. Made us important during the good time and also made us important during the bad time.	Organisation B acted with urgency and made sure to instil stability and make them feel secure: that they will be taken care of by the organisation.	Need for clear and transparent communication to instil sense of stability.
178	P10	An employee transferred to Company A after the peak of the crisis. Comparative experience. Receiving 70% of the salary.	P10: You can even hear from my voice the happy moment I can share with you, the positive moment. I could not complain. There was nurturing, security, assurance aspect during this period.	The employee felt nurtured and safe with Company B during the crisis.	Empathy as an important factor to address insecurities.

Appendix F: Research Ethics Form (RKC Online Campus -Thesis Repository)

[Editor's note: the Research Ethics forms changed in 2022]

7/9/2021

RKC OnlineCampus - Thesis Repository

Application for ethical approval

University approval status: **APPROVED**

RESEARCH ETHICS FORM

Title of research: Crisis leadership and its impact on organisational performance during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Please indicate whether any of the below apply to you:



Research involving living human participants, their tissue or their data. **If you interview or survey people, this must be ticked.**

Research with the potential for adverse environmental impact.

Research involving NHS patients, staff or resources.

Scientific and medical research involving animals.

PROVIDE AN OUTLINE OF THE PROJECT

Everyone must complete this brief outline. This information communicates to those who are asked to approve the research what the project entails.

Where will you get your research material?

Documents:

Unpublished



Published

Existing databases

Other:

Online or social media:

Blogs

Chat rooms

☒ Other: e-books

From people by:

☒ Interviews

Focus groups

Questionnaires

Other:

Biological, medical or social data from:

Animals

Members of the public

Medical patients

Social care patients

Other research material:

If human participants are involved are they:

Under 16

☒ Adults able to give consent

Adults unable to give consent

Briefly describe your project

All fields in this section are required.

Outline:

What leadership processes and behaviours can sustain performance during the current economic crisis within the case study company?

Aims:

To critically review the literature pertaining to crisis leadership.

To gather and analyse information on Company A leadership during the crisis.

To identify integrated leadership processes perceived to achieve sustainable performance during crisis and compare it to relevant theories.

Methods:

The research will apply a case study method through a qualitative (semi-structured interviews) method of data collection due to the small sample size. Candidates will include ten to twelve members, representing 28% of the personnel of different seniority, from different departments, whom the studied phenomena have directly impacted. Interviews will be conducted one on one, through video meetings or face to face. Each interview will last 45 minutes to 1 hour. The interviews will be audio-recorded, subject to each interviewee's consent, with themes noted in the researcher's diary.

themselves. These require particular attention.

3. Will the study require the co-operation of a gatekeeper to give access to, or to help recruit, participants?

Examples include head teachers giving access to schools, ministers giving access to congregations, group leaders publicising your research.

• NO

4. Will it be necessary for participants to take part in the study without their knowledge or consent at the time?

Examples might be studies of group behaviour or the use of data that was not intentionally collected for research.

• NO

5. Will the study involve recruitment of patients through the NHS?

There are particular issues and procedures required if the research will involve NHS users.

• NO

6. Will inducements be offered to participants?

This could include direct payments, the offer of being entered in a prize draw, or, for students, the offer of course credit for participation. It does not include the payment of legitimate expenses.

• NO

7. Does the study involve participants who are particularly vulnerable or unable to give informed consent?

You must answer 'yes' if any participants are under 18. Adults with learning disabilities, the frail elderly, or anyone who may be easily coerced due to lack of capacity is considered vulnerable. If you teach and you wish to research your own students, they should be classed as potentially vulnerable.

• NO

Data collection

Where the collection of data involves more than trivial risk to participants researchers must weigh carefully the necessity of the procedure, the level of possible harm, and the benefits of the research.

8. Will the study require participants to commit extensive time to the study?

Single-session interviews or completing questionnaires once or twice would not be considered excessive, but long-term studies with multiple sampling, intensive data gathering over a day or more, or long interviews and questionnaires that take some hours to complete might fall into this category.

• NO

9. Are drugs, placebos or any other substances to be administered to participants, or will the study involve invasive, intrusive or potentially harmful procedures of any kind?

The research approval is being obtained from the CEO of the case study organisation. Selected participants do not report directly to the researcher. However, due to the researcher being an employee of the case study organisation and regardless of the close professional relationships with the participants, the researcher will be sure to inform potential candidates (via email) that participation is voluntary, and any candidate can withdraw at any time. The email will include a short description of the project, including what is expected of the respondent and a consent form.

Participants' names, job titles and departments will be coded and securely stored separately from the interview notes or recordings. The researcher will store the data securely and will ensure the confidentiality and anonymity of the interviewees.

INITIAL SCREENING CHECKLIST

Please complete the initial screening checklist by clicking either 'Yes' or 'No' in **each** row:

Subject area

If the research involves matters of social, political or personal sensitivity you need to be aware of the boundary between legitimate academic enquiry and unnecessarily offensive or illegal behaviour.

1. **Will the research require the collection of primary source material that might possibly be seen as offensive or considered illegal to access or hold on a computer?**

Examples might be studies related to state security, pornography, abuse or terrorism. Check the [Prevent Duty Guidance for Higher Education](#).

OR

Does your research concern groups which may be construed as terrorist or extremist?

If your answer to this question is "Yes", you must complete and submit the supplementary form available as an appendix to your Research Ethics approval form. **You will also need to complete Appendices A and B at the end of the form to ensure secure data storage for security-sensitive information.**

• NO

2. **Will the study involve discussion or disclosure of information about sensitive topics?**

This may involve legal issues that are nonetheless sensitive (e.g. sexual orientation, or states of health), or topics where illegal behaviour could be revealed (e.g. abuse, criminal activity, under-age drinking or sexual activity).

• NO

Participants: recruiting and consent

If the research involves collecting data from people you need to be aware of issues related to ensuring that they are able to give informed consent to participate where appropriate. This means being aware of how people are recruited, and whether they understand what information is being collected and why. In some cases data collection has to be covert, or informed consent is not possible from the participants

Even simple procedures such as tasting sessions might be dangerous if participants have allergies, so tick yes if the research involves any substance trials.

• NO

10. If there are experimental and control groups, will being in one group disadvantage participants?

Examples might be testing new teaching methods where pupils without the trial procedure may be disadvantaged, or trying a new procedure where the outcomes are uncertain.

• NO

11. Is an extensive degree of exercise or physical exertion involved?

If participants are unused to such exercise it could put them at risk, so it is important for researchers to be aware of this and communicate it to volunteers.

• NO

12. Will blood or tissue samples be obtained from participants?

These procedures require specialist training and are covered by particular ethical codes.

• NO

13. Is pain or more than mild physical discomfort likely to result from the study?

• NO

14. Could the study induce psychological stress or anxiety or cause harm or negative consequences beyond the risks encountered in normal life?

This might be because the subject area is sensitive, the nature of task (e.g. decision-making under pressure), or the participants are particularly vulnerable to stress or anxiety (e.g. those with a history of poor mental health).

• NO

ROUTE: 2 (MORE INFO)

COMMENTS TO STUDENT

06.04.2021 14:36 *by your supervisor:* You have addressed the key research ethics issues in this application George Boak 6 April 2021